The appeal of electoral autocracy: Assessing citizens' revealed societal preferences*

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Abstract

Are citizens willing to trade democratic institutions and practices for more authoritarian alternatives? If so, what do they prioritize and why? We investigate this experimentally by exposing over 35,000 respondents from 32 different countries – both democracies and autocracies – to a series of hypothetical countries, asking them to choose the country they would prefer to live in. We vary the following attributes of the countries: the presence of (various) democratic practices, cultural-social characteristics, and economic and physical security. Based on this, we investigate expectations on how citizens may trade democracy against economic and physical security. We find that citizens are highly committed to free and fair elections. However, many citizens are willing to trade executive constraints to gain economic prosperity. These results are mostly uniform across various country- and individual-specific characteristics. Hence, citizens appear to value what the typical electoral autocrat claims to provide: elected leaders and (economic) safety.

Keywords: Democracy; authoritarian contract; electoral autocracies; survey experiment.

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1 Introduction

The recent wave of autocratization has raised the question of whether the normative power of democracy is less universal than what has often been assumed. Although support for democracy seems to remain strong in many countries (Wuttke, Gavras and Schoen 2022*a*), we have seen a decline in support for democracy in several advanced democracies (Foa and Mounk 2016, 2017) – with this trend most pronounced among younger generations that seem to be 'democrats in name only' (Wuttke, Gavras and Schoen 2022*a*: 416). Yet, as recent work has highlighted, asking citizens to state their support for democracy in a survey may not capture genuine commitments to democracy (Graham and Svolik 2020; Frederiksen 2022). Although citizens may express support for democracy *everything else equal*, in reality, citizens have a range of other preferences and priorities, and are often faced with trade-offs between democracy and other desirable societal characteristics such as economic prosperity, safety or preferred cultural traits.

We shed new light on commitments to democracy by asking citizens: What society would you prefer to live in? More specifically, we expose 35,000 survey respondents from 32 different countries to a series of hypothetical country profiles, whereby we vary the following country attributes: specific characteristics of democracy (elections, civil liberties, executive constraints), economic prosperity, crime, and cultural-social characteristics (gender equality and ethnic/cultural diversity). Respondents are then asked which country they would prefer to live in. This conjoint experimental design allows us to explore whether people "give up" support for democracy when faced with trade-offs between democratic aspects such as elections and executive constraints, and other societal characteristics. When citizens are asked directly about how desirable they consider a democratic society to be, they will often make other assumptions about these societies - such as inferring that they are more economically prosperous or less prone to crime and violence. By isolating the importance of democracy vis-a-vis other societal features, we can examine to what extent citizens are willing to trade off democracy at

the societal level, and, if so, for what.

Our large sample of countries – which, importantly, includes both autocracies and democracies – allows for systematic (observational) analyses of how country-specific factors such as regime type and economic development affect understandings of and preferences for democracy, and similar analyses of how individual characteristics of the respondent matter (e.g. economic security, pre-existing democracy support).

Apart from the study by Adserà, Arenas and Boix (2023), existing research on democratic trade-offs has studied choices between hypothetical political candidates to national or local legislatures, focusing mainly on trade-offs between candidates' anti-democratic statements/behavior and political factors such as party affiliation, polarization (Graham and Svolik 2020), or candidate competence (Frederiksen 2022). While this literature offers invaluable insights into how potential democratic violations by candidates influence voting behavior, our approach of studying characteristics of societies at large allows us to directly investigate citizens' willingness to accept less democratic forms of government – rather than the potential that democracy could ultimately be undermined by the behavior of a single candidate. As we consider trade-offs between democratic institutions at the country-level against a range of other societal outcomes we also move past the focus on political trade-offs in existing literature, by comparing political, economic, social, and cultural dimensions to assess whether people are willing to give up political freedoms and democratic institutions to gain other desirable outcomes.

We investigate a set of pre-registered hypotheses centering around an influential explanation for the appeal of authoritarianism, pointing to citizens' need for security and stability. It has been argued that citizens who do not feel sufficiently secure – either economically, physically, or culturally – are more open to authoritarian forms of government promising to provide such security (Matovski 2021). Our research aims to investigate the merits of this "security hypothesis", by considering whether, and to what extent, citizens are willing to trade off democracy for more authoritarian alternatives when the latter offer physical and material security, and whether

(observed) individual-level or country-level variation in security influences willingness to give up democracy. We thereby build on the theory of the "authoritarian social contract", whereby citizens are willing to relinquish democratic liberties and institutions in exchange for economic well-being, including public goods provision by the authoritarian regime (Desai, Olofsgård and Yousef 2009; De Mesquita and Smith 2010). This core assumption of the theory has not been tested at the individual-level or outside authoritarian contexts, and our paper fills this gap.

Our research demonstrates the powerful appeal of free and fair elections. Having free and fair elections is the strongest determinant of respondents' choice of country they would prefer to live in, and this is quite uniform across different countries and individuals. As our design forces people to think of democratic institutions separately from economic and social conditions that are very strongly correlated in the world we live in, this result can be understood as new evidence that citizens value free and fair elections independently of other associated societal characteristics.

However, citizens are much less concerned with democracy in the form of institutional constraints on the executive, which receives a lower priority than economic security when respondents decide on where they want to live. Assessing our trade-off argument, we show that citizens are willing to trade executive constraints against economic concerns, as the majority of respondents are willing to accept a society where "political leaders can rule without constraints from parliaments or courts" to gain more economic prosperity. Economic security also matters more than free speech, although free speech is more important to respondents than executive constraints.

These findings suggest that citizens appear to value what the typical electoral autocrat at least *claims* to provide: elected leaders and (economic) safety (Von Soest and Grauvogel 2018) while being less concerned with the concentration of power in the hands of such electoral autocrats – at the expense of the opposition and the judiciary. Our findings, therefore, are consistent with the notion that the "authoritarian contract" has considerable popular appeal. Interestingly,

these findings are rather global, as we find strikingly little heterogeneity. For instance, citizens prioritize economic prosperity over constraints on the executive across different regime types and macro-economic conditions. While the percentage of citizens who are willing to trade off executive constraints for economic prosperity is highest in non-democratic countries such as Venezuela (58 %) and Singapore (59 %), it is pretty significant also in mature countries such as Australia (49 %) and the United Kingdom (51 %).

To be sure, electoral autocrats may in practice often – although not always and to varying degrees – manipulate elections to increase their own likelihood of electoral success, thereby not even offering free and fair elections. Yet, electoral autocrats usually make sure to keep up the appearance that they are elected through free and fair elections, to draw legitimacy from the pretense of representing the "will of the people" – even when they are undermining the balance of power and civil liberties. According to our findings, keeping up this appearance may pay off, in terms of popular support by citizens valuing free and fair elections.

2 Mass Support for Democracy

How robust is citizens' support for democracy, and when and why are citizens willing to tolerate and support more authoritarian alternatives to democracy? This question has come to the forefront amidst evidence of a global wave of autocratization, affecting an increasing number of countries and citizens across the globe (e.g. Maerz et al. 2020). Most contemporary instances of autocratization are initiated by democratically elected leaders and parties, that gradually undermine democracy from within once they are in power (Lührmann and Lindberg 2019*a*; Levitsky and Ziblatt 2019). Often, these leaders continue to be popular among citizens even after having exposed their authoritarian tendencies, suggesting that citizens in many countries may be more open to non-democratic alternatives than what has previously been assumed. Up until recently, it was often assumed that support for democracy was relatively widespread across the globe, supported by insights from cross-national surveys such as the World Values Survey, showing

that a large majority of citizens across the globe tend to support democracy when asked, even though there is substantial variation between countries (Wuttke, Gavras and Schoen 2022*b*; Norris 2017). Yet, a growing body of recent literature has questioned this insight.

Several studies – from various contexts – indicate that questions asking directly about citizens' support for democracy (as an abstract concept) may overestimate actual commitments to democracy. When citizens choose between political candidates, a candidate's commitment to democratic principles is only one of several concerns that are considered. Drawing on a candidate choice-design, Graham and Svolik (2020) shows that American citizens are more tolerant of behavior or statements that violate democratic principles by a candidate that represents their "own" political party and that political polarization increases acceptance of anti-democratic behavior. Frederiksen (2022) finds that citizens are willing to trade off democratic principles against competence when deciding between political candidates. Hence, while citizens may generally be supportive of democracy *everything else being equal*, they may often have political priorities that are considered more important than democracy. Hence, while citizens may very well value democracy, they trade it off against other political concerns.

Although these findings indicate that many citizens have political priorities that are considered more important than protecting democratic principles, they also raise further questions about the potential trade-offs citizens make between democracy and other concerns. First, as previous studies have focused on choices between (hypothetical) sets of political candidates, they may overestimate citizens' willingness to accept more authoritarian systems at the macro level. In particular, citizens may be willing to tolerate seemingly undemocratic statements or behavior among political candidates because they do not consider it credible that supporting this candidate will actually harm or undermine democracy in their own country. This could either be because they do not think that the political candidate will implement their undemocratic stance into politics once in power, or because they think that democratic institutions in their country are strong enough to resist attempts at undermining it from the candidate in question. It could

also be because they do not consider the statements expressed by candidates as violations of democratic principles, let alone a threat to democracy as such (Grossman et al. 2022; Krishnarajan 2022). To get a better sense of this, it is necessary to study not only the trade-offs that voters and citizens make when choosing between particular candidates but also when asked to choose between democracy and other outcomes at the societal level.

Second, and related, citizens may emphasize different issues – and may reason differently – when making trade-offs between sets of political candidates, compared to when considering what the most desirable societies are. For instance, casting a vote for or supporting a political candidate may not necessarily reflect agreement with that candidate on his or her policies (including on democracy-related issues), but sometimes be an expression of social identity, or it may be a "protest vote" – as a way of expressing discontent with incumbents or opposing candidates (Alvarez, Kiewiet and Núñez 2018). Hence, there is not always a perfect or even strong link between the societal preferences that citizens have and the issues they emphasize when facing a choice between candidates.

Finally, while existing research has highlighted important political factors that influence willingness to tolerate undemocratic behavior from political candidates – including, e.g., political competence and partisanship – citizens should also factor in a wide range of other concerns when reasoning about the importance of democracy – be it economic, social, or cultural factors. While a candidate-choice study could technically be used to study how statements or promises on economic or social issues shape support for candidates, it does not allow for exploring how non-political outcomes are traded off against (various aspects of) democracy as a political system at the country-level.

Speaking to these issues, Adserà, Arenas and Boix (2023) draw on a comparable design to ours, investigating whether citizens in the United States, France, and Brazil are willing to trade elections against other outcomes. They paint an optimistic picture about the future of democracy, concluding that "having democratic institutions strongly trumps all other considerations

in determining the optimal society for an overwhelming majority of citizens" (Adserà, Arenas and Boix 2023: 1). Yet, their exclusive focus on elections – in two old democracies (the UK and USA) and one intermediate democracy (Brazil) – may paint a too rosy picture of citizens' commitment to democracy.

On this background, we shed new light on the strength and nature of citizens' support for democracy across 32 countries, by studying the trade-offs that citizens in a variety of contexts make between different aspects of democracy and other desirable societal outcomes.

3 Democracy versus Economic and Non-economic Security

Prominent theories on political attitudes and preference formation suggest that citizens' perceived insecurity is a powerful predictor of attitudes – including preferences for democracy. For instance, early contributions such as Fromm (1957) argued that when faced with an uncertain world and lack of direction, people will "escape from freedom" by embracing authoritarianism over democracy. At the micro-level, this assumption usually builds on theories assuming that preferences are hierarchical, in that they progress from basic to more complex. In particular, the influential theory of Maslow (1958) on the "hierarchy of needs" argues that our most basic needs relate to being existentially secure – i.e. not being uncertain about whether you and your kind will live tomorrow. Food, water, and protection from physical harm, which are to some extent provided by the state, are required to secure a basic level of existential security. Only if these needs are met can we progress to higher-level needs – with "self-actualization" being on top of the pyramid.

Applying this framework to evolving preferences for freedom and democracy more specifically, one could argue that demand for the latter will start developing once the lower-level needs are provided for (Inglehart 2005; Welzel 2013). As basic needs are provided for, citizens gain more individual resources and experience a widened scope of possible human activities. This

strengthened autonomy should yield opportunities to focus on other "higher-level needs", beyond a narrow focus on securing the means necessary to survive, and increase citizens' demands for even more free choice and control over their own lives (Welzel 2013). In other words, safety and resources direct people's attention toward the demand for freedom and human choice, and this should increase commitments to democratic institutions including free and fair elections of political leaders and individual civil rights.

Authoritarian preferences may develop due to perceived insecurity driven by the experience of economic and material strain. In these circumstances, citizens might search for strong local or national leadership that can provide the needed security. Authoritarian leaders may be (perceived as) better capable of offering a swift response to challenges to physical insecurity, for instance through harsh policies that are "tough on crime", or by being willing to take swift measures to combat poverty and unemployment. Apart from being preferred for their perceived ability to offer policies that enhance security, authoritarian leaders may also provide a sense of comfort in uncertain times.

The role of security considerations in shaping regime preferences has received quite a bit of attention in the authoritarian context, where buying off citizens is considered a quid-pro-quo arrangement that is linked to the regime's economic resources and performance. The authoritarian contract hypothesis states that "citizens relinquish political rights for economic security" (Desai, Olofsgård and Yousef 2009: 93). The literature on the rentier states illustrates this argument as well: as long as the resource-rich regime can perform and provide material well-being for its citizens, citizens will stay out of the political arena and not demand a reform of the political power architecture (Beblawi and Luciani 1987; Ross 1999).

One implication of this theoretical framework is that citizens will prioritize economic and physical security over democracy – when faced with a situation where they have to choose one over the other. Based on this, we state our first hypothesis as follows:

Hypothesis 1 *People value material and physical security over democratic institutions and political rights.*

Alternatively, we might expect differences in contextual or individual characteristics, which affect whether someone values material and physical security over democratic institutions. Based on the extensive literature on public opinion and attitude formation, we expect that preferences are formulated about individuals' experiences and prior beliefs (Zaller et al. 1992). We distinguish four possible reference points: The national economic context, the national political context, an individual's economic situation, and finally an individual's pre-existing democratic attitudes. Based on these reference points we formulate three additional hypotheses on the trade-off between economic/physical security and democracy to capture the heterogeneous effects.

Firstly, we expect that – when given the choice – people who live in poorer and less generous (macro) contexts value material and physical security more than democratic institutions and political rights. People who live in more prosperous contexts, on the other hand, should be less concerned about these basic security outcomes and place a higher value on democratic outcomes. Similarly, as follows from the mechanisms discussed above on hierarchical preferences and insecurity, people who are personally struggling more economically are expected to prioritize material and physical security outcomes over democracy compared to those who live comfortably. This argument is summarized by the second hypothesis:

Hypothesis 2 *Compared to those living comfortably, people who experience economic hardship place a higher value on material and physical security over democratic institutions and political rights.*

Secondly, we expect the political context in which people live to shape the relative value of economic development and democracy. Those living in democracies are exposed to social

norms to defend democracy, which were shaped by democratic education, family socialization, and the general public discourse (Fuchs-Schündeln and Schündeln 2015). Based on this, we expect the following:

Hypothesis 3 *Compared to those living in autocracies, people who live in democracies place a higher value on democratic institutions and political rights over material and physical security (**H3a**). This relationship is stronger, the older the democratic system is (**H3b**).*

Hypothesis 3b implies that in new democracies, people only value a country if it has democratic institutions/rights AND material and physical security.

Further, we expect pre-existing democratic attitudes to impact the assessment respondents make when evaluating the relative importance of security and democracy. Our next hypothesis is hence:

Hypothesis 4 *Those with stronger stated support for democracy value democratic institutions and political rights more than material and physical security.*

3.1 Non-economic Threat: The Role of Social Conservatism

Feelings of insecurity and perceived threats, that may trigger demands for protection against these threats, can emerge not only from perceived economic and material insecurity but also from perceived cultural threats. For instance, the "cultural backlash theory" argues that there has been an increasing value divide between socially conservative and socially liberal citizens in many countries (Norris and Inglehart 2019). As many societies have experienced more socially progressive policies, for instance in areas such as LGBT rights, multi-culturalism, gender equality, and abortion policies, and many citizens have become significantly more liberal on these issues, other segments of society – that hold more socially traditional values – feel culturally "left behind" according to this theory.

One thing that is common to socially traditional preferences is the inclination to preserve society the way it has traditionally been, but also to favor conformity over diversity and to emphasize and prefer members of in-groups while being hostile to out-groups that may violate conformity and threaten traditional values (Stenner 2005; Feldman 2003). Feeling that the world is changing too rapidly and that this creates uncertainty and anxiety, those with socially conservative preferences feel increasingly more threatened by the recent cultural developments. When exposed to this feeling of cultural insecurity, citizens may place less emphasis on freedom and democratic institutions, in line with the mechanism discussed above on how security triggers more basic "survival preferences". At the same time, citizens may place such a strong emphasis on cultural conservatism that they may be willing to trade off democratic institutions to secure their "own values". Again, a type of evolutionary mechanism may play out, as citizens will only be willing to prioritize democratic institutions and liberties once they feel secure.

At the same time, citizens with such a value-conservative mindset may be more inclined to prefer an authoritarian government – due to its (perceived) ability and willingness to take measures to restrict cultural liberalism, for instance through restricting migration or implementing more restrictive abortion laws. This aligns with studies showing that feeling threatened by cultural progressivism is an explanation for support for authoritarian movements and strongman leaders such as Donald Trump in the U.S. (e.g. Wright and Esses 2019) and European populist leaders such as Victor Orban in Hungary (e.g. Donovan 2021). This yields the final hypothesis:

Hypothesis 5 *Compared to those with progressive values, people with more socially and culturally traditional attitudes place a higher value on socially conservative societies over democratic institutions and political rights.*

4 Research Design

We employ a well-powered, paired-profile conjoint experiment in 32 countries to test our hypotheses. Specifically, we randomly assign characteristics to hypothetical country profiles on seven dimensions: Elections, separation of power, free speech, the economy, crime, gender equality, and cultural diversity. As part of the conjoint experiment, respondents are shown random combinations of attributes from each of the seven dimensions and are then asked which country they prefer to live in. Respondents were recruited via social media advertisement on the Meta platforms Facebook and Instagram and data was collected in Qualtrics. 35,281 respondents participated in our study, yielding 282,560 country-profile observations in total.

The study received ethical approval[1] and was pre-registered on December 14, 2022, before any data collection commenced.[2]

4.1 Data Collection

Data collection for this project took place between December 16, 2022, and May 20, 2023. We recruited participants by using paid advertisements on social media platforms, in particular Facebook and Instagram. Participants were then directed to our survey hosted on Qualtrics. This data collection method, combining the extraordinary reach of social media platforms with the flexibility of online survey tools, uniquely facilitated the fielding of our complex survey design across more than thirty countries. Compared to working with online panel companies, this method offered us a standard recruitment process across different countries and full control over this process.

[1] The study received ethical approval (number: 400210195) from the Ethics Committee of the College of Social Sciences at the University of Glasgow on May 17, 2022. More details on the ethical considerations of this research are discussed in Appendix A.

[2] The public registration of the hypotheses, data collection procedure, data manipulation, and analysis plan is available at `https://osf.io/pejzx` .

A disadvantage of online surveys is that the sample will be biased towards certain demographic groups due to the self-selection effect. This is especially the case in less developed countries with lower levels of internet penetration.[3] We took some measures to minimize biases in our sample and maximize the data quality. First, our advertisements offered material incentives, i.e., a draw for a $500 voucher for Amazon or a similar national online store in countries where Amazon is not available, to encourage the participation of social media users with lower levels of education and political interest (Neundorf and Öztürk 2022). We also used Facebook's targeting options, based on age, gender, and education, to ensure that our advertisements have been delivered widely across these categories (Neundorf and Öztürk 2023).

Overall, we reached 2.5 Million people who saw our recruitment advertisements. Of this, 35,281 people provided a valid response to at least one country comparison. In Appendix G, we compare key demographics between our sample and the populations for each country. Our samples are on average fairly representative in terms of age and gender, while still over-representing highly educated people and those interested in politics to a certain extent, which is common in other types of online opt-in panels as well.

4.1.1 Case Selection

Some of our hypotheses focus on the impact of the context in which respondents live, as we expect economic (H2) and political (H3) factors to shape how they will evaluate the hypothetical countries asked to compare. Cases to include in our study were therefore chosen to have variation based on the level of democracy (democratic versus autocratic) and economic development (low and high). We further had two more practical constraints on case selection. First, since we used paid social media advertisements to recruit research participants, our sample is formed

[3] Facebook users represent the populations of the countries in our sample to a varying degree, ranging from 83% of the population that regularly uses Facebook in Singapore to 7% in Uganda. The average proportion of the national population active on Facebook in our sampled countries is 47%.

from countries where Facebook and Instagram are widely used, which we define as having at least 2 Million regular Facebook users.[4] Second, to maximize comparability across countries and minimize costs, we prioritized countries in which the general population understands English or Spanish, the two main languages used in our surveys.[5] We further added Turkey, as the country represents a typical contemporary electoral autocracy and is relatively more developed than most autocracies in our sample.

Based on these considerations, we include 32 countries in our study.[6] Figure 1 plots our cases by their liberal democracy score (V-Dem) and their human development index (United Nations). The figure demonstrates that we have considerable variation in the two key contextual variables.

4.2 Conjoint Experimental Design

The essence of this experiment is a comparison of two hypothetical countries. Each respondent was asked to compare two countries five times.[7] After being presented with the hypothetical country profiles, survey respondents were asked which country they wanted to live in, which

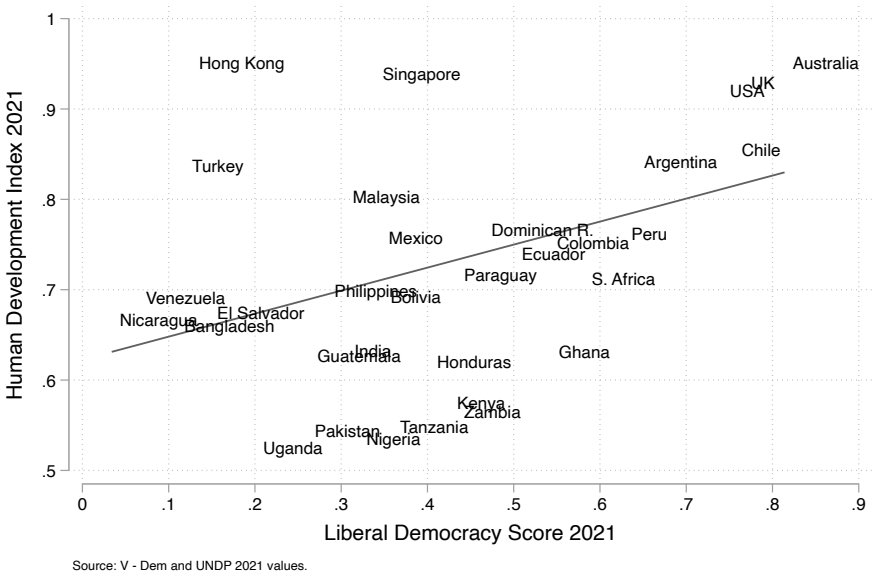
[4] To determine the number of active Facebook users we used the following website: `https://worldpopulationreview.com/country-rankings/facebook-users-by-country`. The Facebook population in our sample ranges from 416 Million in India to 2.5 Million in Zambia and Nicaragua.

[5] Please see Figure A.17 for documentation that the results are relatively homogeneous between English and Spanish-speaking countries, or Figure A.18 showing that the results are not driven by language-proficient respondents.

[6] List of countries: Argentina, Australia, Bangladesh, Bolivia, Chile, Colombia, Dominican Republic, Ecuador, El Salvador, Ghana, Guatemala, Honduras, Hong Kong, India, Kenya, Malaysia, Mexico, Nicaragua, Nigeria, Pakistan, Paraguay, Peru, Philippines, Singapore, South Africa, Tanzania, Turkey, Uganda, United Kingdom, the United States of America, Venezuela, and Zambia. In Table A.1 in the Appendix we list the number of respondents and profile observations per country. Additional results are presented in Figure A.15, where we account for imbalances in sample size across countries by introducing country-fixed effects to our main results.

[7] After having fielded the survey in Turkey, we reduced the number of tasks from ten to five. We did this due to concerns about high dropout rates. Dropout improved tremendously after conducting this change. In Turkey, respondents provided an average of only 8.83 effective observations, corresponding to 44.15% of the maximum of twenty observations. In the remaining countries, we obtained an average of 7.93 effective observations per respondent, corresponding to 79.3% of the maximum of ten observations.

Figure 1: Case selection by democratic and human development



is our main outcome variable. We further asked respondents to rate the quality of life in each country, which is used as a secondary outcome and results for this variable are presented in Appendix C. Each country profile was randomly assigned one attribute for the following seven dimensions: Elections, separation of power, free speech, economy, crime, equal pay between genders, and ethnic diversity. The first three tap into various aspects of democracy, both electoral democracy and two aspects of liberal democracy (separation of power and free speech). Economy and crime tap into societies' level of security, distinguishing between material/economic security and physical security (from violent crime). The two final dimensions tap into cultural characteristics, including gender equality (measured using a measure of wage equality) and ethnic/cultural diversity. Table 1 shows the attribute dimensions and the levels randomly assigned to each dimension. Each dimension has two distinct attributes representing opposing ends.[8]

[8] Appendix B includes a screenshot of one example country comparison as was displayed in the survey. To avoid an ordering effect of how the dimensions were presented to respondents, we randomized the order by blocs of themes: democracy, security, and society. These were then fixed by respondents with every respondent seeing all five country pairs in the same order of blocs.

Table 1: Dimensions and attributes for conjoint experiment

Dimensions	Attributes
Elections	Citizens elect their leaders in free and fair elections Citizens go to the polls, but elections are neither free nor fair
Separation of power	Political leaders are constrained by parliament and courts Political leaders can rule without constraints from parliament or courts
Free speech	People can criticize the government in public without getting prosecuted by authorities People could get prosecuted by authorities when criticizing the government in public
Economy	People generally live comfortably on their income and can afford most things that they need Many people struggle to live on their income and must make decisions about what they can afford
Crime	Crime rates in the country are low and stable The country struggles with high crime rates
Equal pay	Men and women have equal wages Men have higher wages than women
Diversity	People living in this country are ethnically and culturally very diverse People living in this country are ethnically and culturally very similar

When choosing and designing these items the dimensions and attributes needed to be general enough to be understood by citizens across all 32 countries that we fielded the survey in. It was also important not to present too many items, as this would make choosing between two countries too complex. For these reasons, we had to exclude potentially interesting dimensions, such as nationalism, foreign policy, or religion. To be sure, the final list of dimensions may vary not only in their content but also in their level of abstraction, which could potentially influence the extent to which respondents prioritize them.[9] For instance, aspects such as separation of power and free speech may be harder to grasp for (some) respondents than the dimension of free and fair elections. We note that this is not necessarily a methodological problem, but rather

[9] We refrained from using more concrete economic attributes, e.g. levels of GDP/per Capita, as we believe this to be more difficult to understand by respondents who live in very different developmental contexts. In their three countries study, Adserà, Arenas and Boix (2023) vary the national and individual income to estimate the actual costs of democracy that people are willing to accept. The advantage of our design compared to theirs is the inclusion of more fine-grained dimensions of democracy (we have three while they have only one attribute) and the inclusion of societal and cultural factors.

a relevant feature of the real world: Some characteristics of society and democracy in particular *are* more abstract and probably harder to grasp also in real life, and this could be a mechanism explaining why some aspects of democracy are valued more than others. To look more closely into respondents' perceptions of these different democratic items, the empirical section also tests the extent to which these different democratic items make respondents assess a country as more or less democratic.

4.2.1 Moderators

In this paper, we focus on the contextual and individual heterogeneity in the trade-off people make between democracy and other societal factors. We therefore split our sample into distinct groups and present the results separately.

For this, we consider the following country-level moderators. Firstly, to test the impact of *macro-level development* (H2) we use the Human Development Index (HDI) provided by United Nations Development Programme (2022). Relying on measures of life expectancy at birth, expected years of schooling, and gross national income per capita, this index captures the level of human development in a country. We present our results using the median split of HDI for our sample, which is 0.7. Secondly, to test the impact of the *regime type* (H3a) we use the 'Regimes of the World' (ROW) indicator by V-Dem to classify our cases into (electoral or liberal) democracies and (closed or electoral) autocracies. We further create the *age of democracy* (H3b) based on the same ROW indicator, where we count the number of years since the country became a democracy to today. Autocratic countries receive the value of 0, while democratic countries receive the value of years since the last democratic transition. We divided democracies into three groups: Young (1-2 years), middle (up to 50 years), and old (over 50 years).

We further include three individual-level moderators, which were measured before respondents were exposed to the country profiles. First, *personal economic standing* (H2) is measured

using the following question: "Which of the following comes closest to how you feel about your household's income nowadays? 1) Living comfortably on present income to 4) very difficult on present income." For the analysis presented below, we collapse categories 1 and 2 (no struggle) as well as 3 and 4 (struggle). Descriptively, the former category makes up 40% of the sample and the latter 60%. The measure is significantly correlated with macro-level development in the expected direction.

Second, individuals' *support for democracy* (H4) is measured using the following question: "Do you agree or disagree with the following statement: Democracy may have its problems, but it is still the best form of government. 1) Strongly agree; 3) neutral; 5) strongly disagree." Again we created two groups by collapsing categories 1 and 2 (high support) and 3 to 5 (low support). The low support-group makes up 28% of the sample, whereas the high support-group makes up 72% of the sample. These numbers are approximately similar across democracies and autocracies.

Third, individual level *social conservatism* (H5) is measured by an index variable that is built on three questions measuring attitudes towards gender equality, homosexuality, and immigration, measuring agreement with the following three statements: "When jobs are scarce, employers should give priority to people born in this country over immigrants," "When jobs are scarce, men should have more right to a job than women," "Homosexuality is justified." Responses ranged from strongly disagree (1) to strongly agree (5) and we created a mean score for the three items. To create two groups for the analysis below, we took the median split of this index.

4.3 Modelling

We use simple linear regression with respondent-clustered standard errors to test our hypotheses (Hainmueller, Hopkins and Yamamoto 2014). Specifically, we regress our preference-to-live

outcome on the country attributes. We calculate Average Marginal Component Effects – denoting the average effect of each individual conjoint factor averaged over the other (randomly assigned) factors – and, to further bolster the intuition of our findings, calculate the exact proportions of citizens willing to trade democracy for security. According to our setup, citizens are willing to trade off democracy when they express stronger desires to live in autocratic countries with high (economic and non-economic) security compared with democratic countries with low security.

We also interact a scale covering democracy with the economic security attribute to compare preferences for bundles scoring high (low) on democracy and low (high) on economic security. The democracy scale is a simple sum scale including the elections, separation of powers, and free speech dimensions. We treat the scale as a categorical variable when estimating this interaction. When testing the heterogeneous effects hypotheses (H2 and onwards), we calculate AMCEs by subgroups.[10]

5 Results

In this section, we present the results in three sub-sections. First, we explore which country features citizens perceive as democratic by showing the effects of all factors on the perceived democraticness of the country profiles. This helps us understand the mechanisms behind our findings, sheds light on core assumptions of our setup, and provides general knowledge about how citizens understand democracy. Second, we investigate citizens' overall willingness to

[10] These modeling choices deviate slightly from our pre-registered specifications. In particular, we pre-registered comparing bundles scoring high (low) on democracy and low (high) on security for each of the subgroups rather than AMCE plots separating each of the dimensions when testing the heterogeneous effects hypotheses. Moreover, we planned on using a combined measure of economic and physical security but ultimately chose to mainly focus on the economy. Specifically, we made these changes as the security dimensions turned out to have very different effects, with the economy mattering substantially more than crime. This means that pooling the dimensions would cover up important heterogeneity. However, pooling the dimensions, as pre-registered, does not make a difference to the overall findings, and we report these pre-registered tests in Appendix D.

trade democracy for security (without conditioning on individual- or country-level characteristics, that is). Third, we condition the findings on theoretically interesting contextual and individual-level factors.

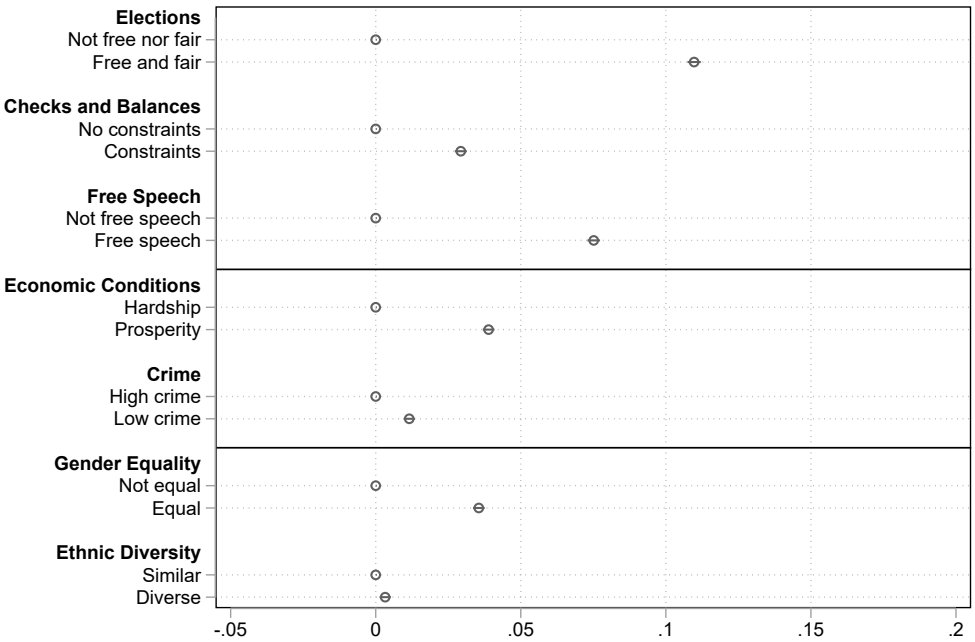
5.1 Manipulation Check: Do People Understand Democracy?

As discussed above, citizens' willingness to prioritize aspects of democracy over other societal characteristics may be influenced by not only the extent to which they value democracy compared to other features but also by *which practices they perceive as democratic*. Previous literature has shown that citizens' understanding of democracy is often quite shallow (Kirsch and Welzel 2019). For instance, many citizens tend to associate the label democracy with other desirable features, such as economic stability or peace (Dalton, Shin and Jou 2007; Ridge 2021). Others tend to mainly understand democracy as being about elections, while not considering liberal aspects such as institutional constraints and political rights as being essential to democracy (e.g., Wunsch, Jacob and Derksen 2022). Hence, to know whether we are meaningfully measuring to what extent citizens are willing to deliberately trade off aspects of democracy against other concerns we also want to find out what they perceive as democratic.

To explore this, we present results from models investigating whether our dimensions tapping into democracy affect respondents' assessments of how democratic a country is, drawing on the following outcome question – scaled from 0 (very low) to 10 (very high) – from our survey: "How would you rate the level of democracy in each country?"? As assessments of democraticness are influenced by other societal features than democratic institutions and practices, we also test whether our dimensions tapping into security and cultural characteristics shape assessments of democraticness.

Our results, summarized in Figure 2, indicate that all three democratic dimensions increase respondents' assessments of how democratic a country is. Yet, elections and free speech matter

Figure 2: AMCEs of all attributes on perceived democraticness across the entire sample (manipulation check)



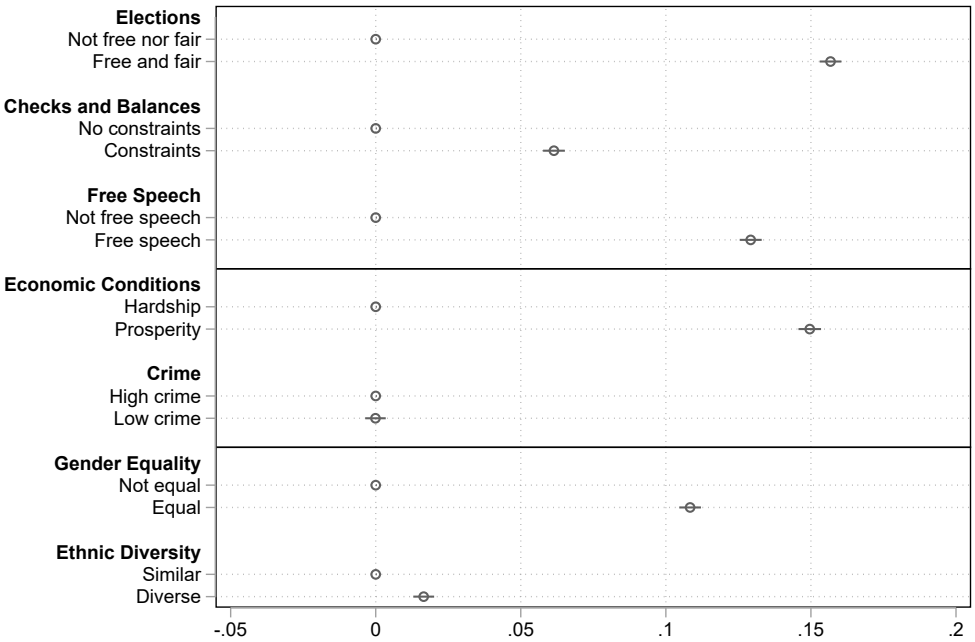
Note: 282,421 observations. Linear regression with country characteristics as independent variables and perceived democraticness as dependent variable. Standard errors are clustered on the respondent level.

considerably more than checks and balances. Factors such as economic security and wage equality are indeed positively related to assessments of democracy, but the ”true” democratic features generally affect perceived democraticness the most. Hence, respondents seem to have a relatively good grasp of what democracy is.

5.2 Main Effects: Citizens Prioritize Elections and Economic Well-Being

As we have now established that the included dimensions of our experiment tap into realistic understandings of what constitutes a democracy, we turn to the question of whether people are willing to trade off these democratic traits for other desirable societal characteristics. Figure 3 presents our main results, pooling all respondents and showing the AMCEs for each of our

Figure 3: AMCEs of all attributes on living preferences across the entire sample.



Note: 282,560 observations. Linear regression with country characteristics as independent variables and living preferences as the dependent variable. Standard errors are clustered on the respondent level.

seven country attributes on our preference-to-live outcome.[11]

We see that, overall, elections and economic prosperity are the factors that influence country choice the most. Specifically, economic prosperity – compared with economic hardship – affects the preference-to-live outcome by 15 percentage points, whereas free and fair elections – compared with not having free nor fair elections – affect the outcome by 16 percentage points. Second, the political features (elections, checks and balances, and free speech) more consistently affect the outcome than the security and diversity features. The difference between the effect of the economy and crime – which does not yield any significant effect – is particularly noticeable. However, it is also clear that citizens prioritize civil liberties (free speech) and hor-

[11] In Appendix D we further present the same results for our secondary outcome of rating the quality of life in each of the countries presented to the respondents for all our hypotheses. Further, we also show AMCEs split by country in Figure A.14.

izontal accountability (checks and balances) less than economic well-being. Especially checks and balances are overshadowed by the economy, which we interpret as signaling that people care more about the citizen-centered aspects of democracy (free speech and elections) than institutional aspects (checks and balances). We thus confirm authoritarian contracts, as people prioritize economic well-being over non-electoral aspects of democracy.

To address our research question more directly, we show the exact proportions of citizens willing to trade aspects of democracy for security in Table 2. As Figure 3 illustrates that the economy is the by far most important security factor, we show the proportions of citizens willing to trade off democracy for economic prosperity by country *and* in pooled format, whereas we stick to the pooled results for crime as well as crime and economy combined.[12] Unsurprisingly, Table 2 also shows that citizens are not willing to trade any aspect of democracy for lower crime. However, a majority of citizens are willing to trade all democratic aspects but elections for economic prosperity: 51% are willing to trade free speech for economic prosperity, while 54% are willing to trade institutional checks on the executive for a better national economy. We do note that these differences appear quite modest substantially – the proportion willing to trade free elections is 49% – but effect sizes are notoriously small in conjoint experiments due to a higher level of statistical noise (Schuessler and Freitag 2020). Thus, especially the difference between willingness to trade elections and institutional checks appears noticeable.

Across countries, citizens also tend to be willing to trade off free speech and they are almost consistently willing to trade off checks and balances for economic prosperity. Only citizens in 8/32 countries are not willing to trade away free speech, whereas Australia is the only country in which a majority of citizens reject trading off institutional checks on the executive. If we add lower crime to economic prosperity, there is no country in the entire sample where a majority of citizens reject trading off horizontal accountability (see Table A.3 in the Appendix). These

[12] See Tables A2 and A3 in the Appendix for results related to crime as well as economy and crime combined split by country.

Table 2: Percentages of citizens willing to trade elections, free speech, and checks on the executive for economic prosperity (in each country and pooled) and absence of crime (pooled).

	Elections	Free speech	Checks	All aspects
Pooled (Crime & Economy)				
Crime	42%	44%	47%	34%
Economy	49%	51%	54%	39%
Both	50%	51%	54%	40%
By Country (Only Economy)				
Argentina	49%	50%	56%	40%
Australia	47%	48%	49%	23%
Bangladesh	48%	51%	53%	38%
Bolivia	49%	49%	54%	38%
Chile	48%	51%	55%	35%
Colombia	50%	50%	56%	43%
Dominican Republic	49%	49%	55%	42%
Ecuador	51%	53%	56%	41%
Ghana	46%	53%	55%	40%
Guatemala	51%	51%	56%	48%
Honduras	52%	52%	58%	44%
Hong Kong	51%	50%	54%	33%
India	50%	51%	53%	43%
Kenya	49%	51%	53%	40%
Malaysia	55%	57%	57%	42%
Mexico	49%	49%	57%	40%
Nicaragua	49%	49%	54%	39%
Nigeria	50%	52%	54%	41%
Pakistan	47%	50%	54%	36%
Paraguay	50%	48%	56%	44%
Peru	50%	50%	56%	39%
Philippines	51%	52%	56%	42%
El Salvador	51%	50%	55%	44%
Singapore	56%	59%	59%	46%
South Africa	50%	50%	54%	39%
Tanzania	48%	50%	51%	37%
Turkey	49%	51%	50%	40%
Uganda	51%	53%	55%	43%
Venezuela	50%	54%	58%	39%
United Kingdom	43%	46%	50%	20%
United States	48%	47%	53%	27%
Zambia	47%	51%	55%	38%

negative news for democracy aside, it is important to emphasize that citizens are generally not willing to trade all three aspects of democracy for security simultaneously.

To further explore trade-offs between democracy and economic security, we compare preferences for high (low) democracy and low (high) security bundles as produced by the factorial interaction between economic security and the democracy scale outlined under Modelling. In Figure 4 we report the eight marginal means produced by this interaction.[13] Figure 4 largely supports the findings highlighted based on prior illustrations. Citizens are generally willing to trade off one aspect of democracy for economic prosperity. We infer this from the result that prosperous countries are preferred over more non-prosperous countries with a one-point improvement in democracy, regardless of whether we focus on the lower or higher end of the democracy scale. For example, a prosperous country with two democratic attributes is preferred over a non-prosperous country with all three democratic attributes. But again, citizens are not willing to trade all aspects of democracy simultaneously, as the most democratic, non-prosperous societies are preferred over the most autocratic prosperous societies.

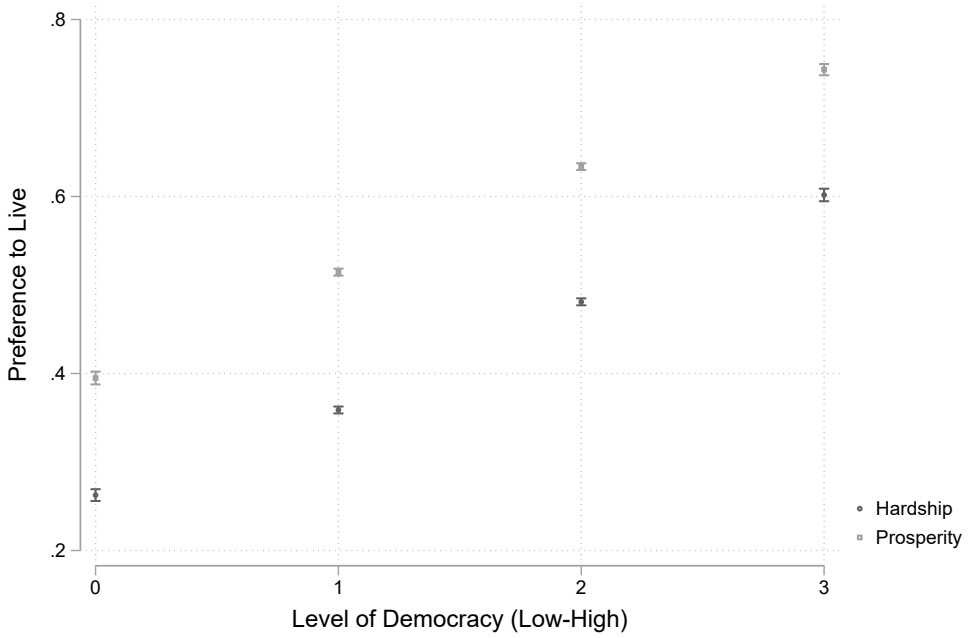
In sum, we find that citizens are willing to trade typical liberal aspects of democracy – in particular institutional checks on the executive – for economic prosperity, although the very core institution of elections weighs similarly to the economy.

5.3 Moderator Analyses: Homogeneous Effects

Thus far, our results play perfectly into the hands of contemporary electoral autocrats, as citizens prioritize what the typical electoral autocrat claims to provide: elections and (economic) safety. But is this the case for all citizens? We now turn to the hypotheses about heterogeneous effects by individual- and macro-level well-being, regime type, support for democracy, and social attitudes. We report subgroup AMCEs for people who do and do not struggle economi-

[13] We present the same figures of marginal means for attribute bundles for all other hypotheses in Appendix D.

Figure 4: Living preferences for high (low) democracy and low (high) security country bundles.



Note: 282,560 observations. Linear regression with our democracy scale and economic prosperity as independent variables, including an interaction term between the two, and living preferences as the dependent variable. Standard errors are clustered on the respondent level.

cally (on the macro-level as well as individually) in Figure 5, for people living in autocracies, new democracies, intermediate democracies, and old democracies in Figure 6, for people with low and high support for democracy in Figure 7, and for people with liberal and conservative attitudes in Figure 8.[14]

For H2-H4 to gain support, we should see that democracy is prioritized less relative to security when an economic struggle is present (H2), in autocracies (H3a), in new democracies compared to old democracies (H3b), and when support for democracy is low (H4). Additionally, H5 gains support if the cultural attributes (gender equality and ethnic diversity) yield greater negative effects than democracy yields positive effects among conservative respondents. Again, the

[14] We split the macro-level security, support for democracy, and social attitude measures at their median values.

cultural attributes are not key to testing H2-H4, whereas the security attributes are not key to testing H5. However, all attributes are included for completeness. Additionally, we conceive of the non-central attributes as placebo attributes for which we do not expect heterogeneous effects. This helps us assess whether, for example, we see heterogeneous effects on all attributes across economic hardship rather than just for the attributes for which we expect it.

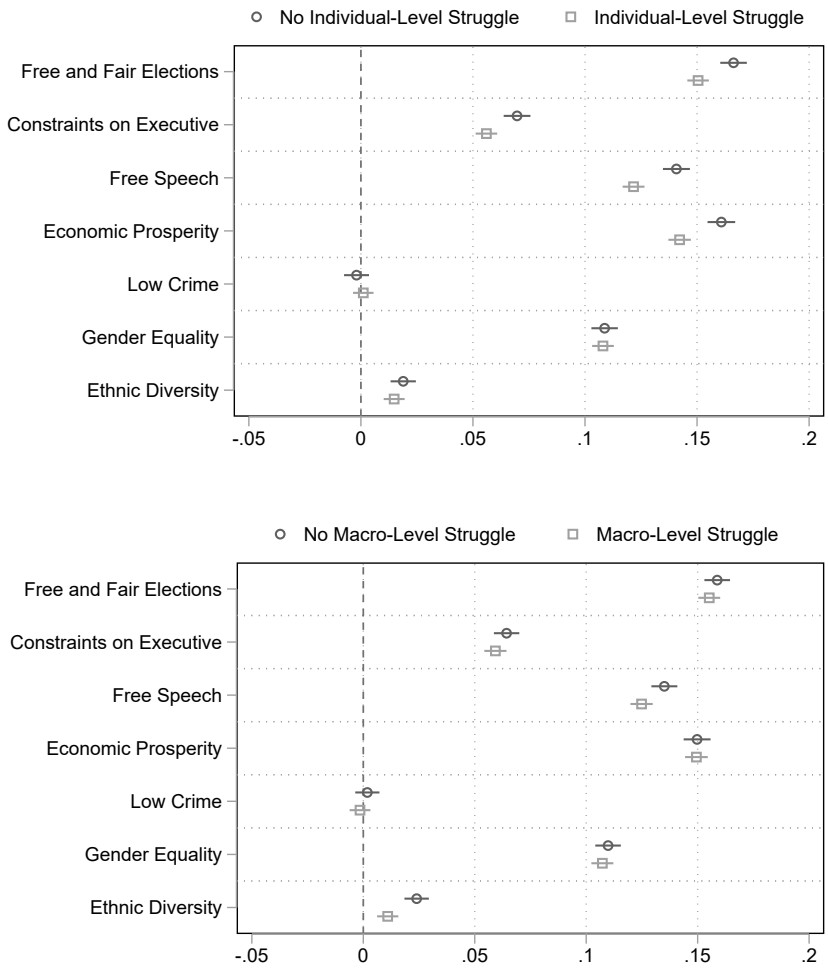
Although we see some differences across the moderating factors, Figures 5-8 generally show that the main findings are relatively homogeneous. For example, Figure 5 shows that the effects of the economy, as well as the democracy factors, are strongest among people who do not struggle economically, but the relative priority of the economy versus democracy does not depend on personal economic hardship. Such prioritization neither depends on macro-level security, which yields even weaker heterogeneity. However, there is a weak tendency for citizens of countries that are more developed to prioritize democracy slightly more. We reject the hypothesis that relative prioritization of security versus democracy depends on economic hardship - whether on the micro or macro level (H2).[15]

Turning to regime differences, Figure 6 shows that the old democracies – the US, the UK, and Australia – stand out by yielding larger effects, in particular concerning the democracy factors, but also somewhat concerning the economy and the cultural attributes.[16]However, citizens living in autocratic contexts are no less inclined to prioritize security over democracy than citizens living in new or intermediate democracies. It is nevertheless noticeable that people living in autocracies to a larger degree buy into the premise of an electoral autocracy by placing more weight on the economy and elections than citizens living in new and intermediate democracies. In sum, we do not find support for the hypothesis that citizens living in democratic contexts place more weight on democracy relative to security (H3a), whereas we do find support for the

[15] One may raise the concern that cognitive capacity confounds the results concerning personal economic hardship. Thus, we show in Figure A.11 in the Appendix that the results are similar for people with low and high education.

[16] We show a figure collapsing democracies to one category in Appendix A.13.

Figure 5: AMCEs of all attributes on living preferences by individual- and macro-level economic conditions.

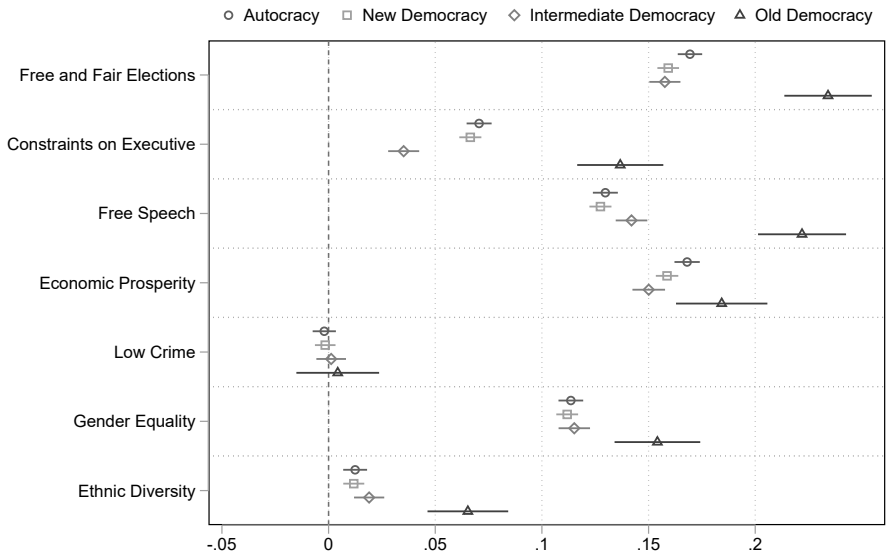


Note: 111,608-170,952 observations depending on the size of economic conditions categories. Linear regression with country characteristics as independent variables and living preferences as the dependent variable, conditioning on our measures of individual- and macro-level economic conditions. Standard errors are clustered on the respondent level.

hypothesis that such a trend materializes with the age of democracy, especially among the most established democracies (H3b).

Next, we further zoom in on possible individual-level heterogeneity. We find support for the hypothesis that citizens with higher support for democracies prioritize living in a democracy

Figure 6: AMCEs of all attributes on living preferences by regime.

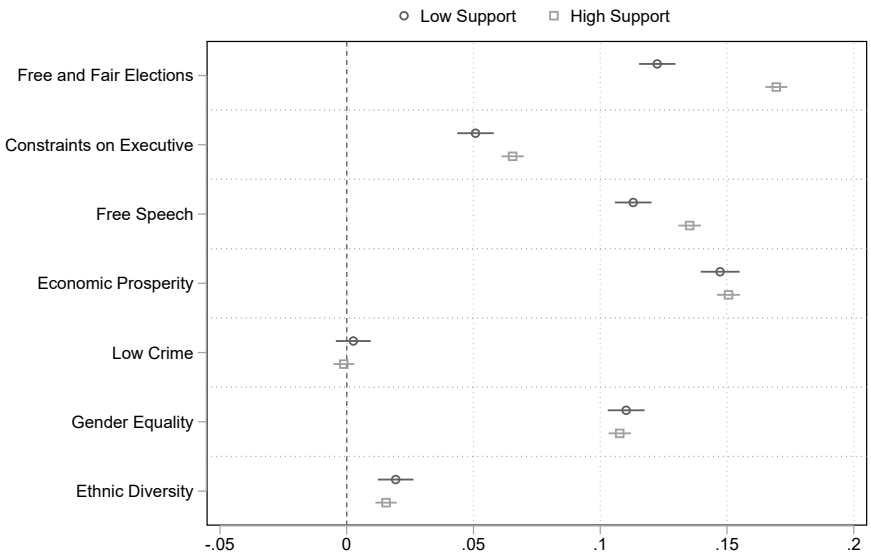


Note: 8,818-150,242 observations depending on the size of regime categories. Linear regression with country characteristics as independent variables and living preferences as the dependent variable, conditioning on our measures of regimes. Standard errors are clustered on the respondent level.

relative to security more than citizens with low support for democracy (H4). Specifically, Figure 7 shows that the effects of the democracy attributes are stronger among citizens with high support for democracy than among citizens with low support, whereas we find no differences concerning the remaining country attributes. Support for democracy therefore affects preferences for living in a democracy uniquely; it does not affect how much citizens value any other country features. This finding by no means strikes us as obvious, as recent studies suggest that support for democracy is a poor predictor – as bad as flipping a coin – of punishment of undemocratic behavior by politicians (e.g., Svolik 2019). Despite recent criticism, our findings thus lend some credibility to measures of support for democracy and show that such measures are good predictors of citizens' preferences of where to live.

Additionally, it is noticeable that support for democracy yields particularly large heterogeneity concerning the effects of free and fair elections. This suggests that citizens mostly have elections in mind when they say they support democracy. Importantly, citizens with high sup-

Figure 7: AMCEs of all attributes on living preferences by individuals' pre-existing democracy support

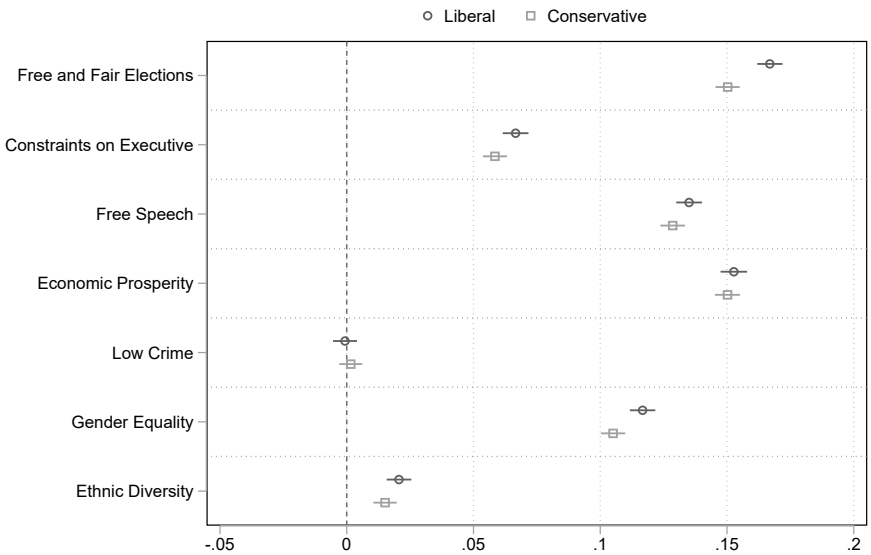


Note: 76,248-206,312 observations depending on the size of democracy support categories. Linear regression with country characteristics as independent variables and living preferences as the dependent variable, conditioning our measures of support for democracy. Standard errors are clustered on the respondent level.

port for democracy do not value economic prosperity, low crime, gender equality, or ethnic diversity more than people with low support for democracy. This suggests that citizens do not have these aspects – which are less central to procedural democracy – in mind when saying they support democracy. We take this – which is largely consistent with our findings regarding understandings of democracy in Figure 2 – as evidence that citizens have a solid understanding of what democracy is and that the expression of general support for democracy (our moderator) might not only describe 'democrats by name only' (Wuttke, Gavras and Schoen 2022*a*: 416).

Finally, we reject the hypothesis that conservative citizens prioritize conservative country traits over democracy (H5). Liberal citizens do value gender equality and ethnic diversity more than conservative citizens, but even conservative citizens view these traits somewhat positively. Additionally, even though liberal citizens value democracy somewhat more than conservative citizens, the effects of the democratic attributes also outweigh the effects of the cultural at-

Figure 8: AMCEs of all attributes on living preferences by individuals' pre-existing social attitudes



Note: 154,960-175,074 observations depending on the size of social attitude categories. Linear regression with country characteristics as independent variables and living preferences as the dependent variable, conditioning our measures of social attitudes. Standard errors are clustered on the respondent level.

tributes among conservative citizens.[17] The results imply that despite the widely documented cultural tensions in many democratic countries, these tensions seem not to affect people's general commitment to democratic institutions, especially elections and individual liberties, as the main priority for a country.

6 Discussion and Conclusion

Across a diverse set of countries and individuals, our results demonstrate that citizens value both economic prosperity and free and fair elections when choosing an ideal society. The central role of economic prosperity in this evaluation is consistent with authoritarian contract theory on the

[17] We show in Figure A.12 in the Appendix that comparing the 10% most conservative respondents to the 10% most liberal respondents also leads to rejection of the hypothesis.

individual level. In addition, as assumed by the theory, core liberal democratic components such as civil rights and executive constraints matter less for citizens. The somewhat surprising finding – at least following authoritarian contract theory – is the importance of elections, as Adserà, Arenas and Boix (2023) already demonstrate.[18] That citizens across such a diverse set of countries value free and fair elections seems to be optimistic news for democracy. However, this interpretation rests on two assumptions. First, people understand what free and fair elections are and hence can detect if elections are fraudulent or not competitive. Second, we would have to assume that free and fair elections are indeed a key characteristic of democracies and not associated with autocracies.

Regarding the first assumption, as far as we are aware, there is no conclusive evidence indicating that citizens have a clear understanding of what free and fair elections entail. The existing literature focuses on how people form their opinions about the quality of their national elections, as well as the accuracy of these assessments (Coffé 2017). Overall, the accuracy of voters' evaluation of their national elections is only moderate and subject to various biases.[19] For example, people's assessment of electoral procedures is affected by their partisanship or whether their preferred party won the election (Cantú and García-Ponce 2015; Ugues Jr 2018; Schaffner 2021; Mochtak, Lesschaeve and Glaurdić 2021). These biases are stronger when people encounter disinformation (Mauk and Grömping 2023) or live in autocracies (Jöst, Vergioglou and Jacob 2022; Wilking 2011). Access to information and its quality generally plays a role in shaping perceptions of electoral integrity (Robertson 2017; Karp, Nai and Norris 2017; Clayton and Willer 2023). In sum, the literature and our own explorative findings suggest that

[18] Their election dimension only refers to "free elections", but does not mention fairness.

[19] In Figure A.20 in the Appendix, we use data from the World Value Survey to explore how accurately respondents assess the quality of their national elections. The results demonstrate that people who live in countries with low to middle levels of electoral quality are overestimating the quality of their national elections. Further, people experiencing well-functioning elections evaluate these more accurately or undervalue the quality of their elections. This implies that many people misperceive what free and fair elections are, as they evaluate their national contexts as too optimistic than what the elections are.

many people might not have an accurate understanding of what free and fair elections are, but even so they clearly associate elections with democracy (as we show above).

Turning to the second assumption on the role of free and fair elections as a defining feature of democracy, we know that the normative power of elections (and democracy more broadly) is often misused by autocrats who run elections to legitimize themselves in power. For example, in May 2023, Erdogan won the presidential elections in Turkey and many observers attribute this victory to a great extent to his authoritarian control over the media, judiciary, and state institutions. Nevertheless, Erdogan claimed on the election night that "Türkiye has successfully completed yet another festival of democracy with the May 14 elections".[20] Erdogan is not the only autocrat who over-claims the freeness and fairness of their national elections, as procedural elements of democracy, such as elections, have become an important part of the legitimization strategy of authoritarian regimes (Schedler 2013; Brunkert 2022). Additionally, most countries do not only claim to be democratic, e.g. in their constitutions (Márquez 2016) or even their name (e.g. the *Democratic* Republic of the Congo), holding elections is as common in autocracies as it is the case in democracies (apart from very few exceptions, e.g. Saudi Arabia, North Korea). This of course does not imply that these elections are free and fair, but autocrats are very skilled in convincing their citizens (especially their supporters) that they are, using tactics such as media propaganda (Schedler 2013).

Contemporary electoral autocracies combine *de jure* competitive elections and purported success in providing material welfare and security to claim legitimacy to their power (Morgenbesser 2017; Von Soest and Grauvogel 2018). Our results suggest that this combination caters exactly to the preferences of citizens. Given that many citizens do not have a well-grounded understanding of what free or fair elections are (due to individual biases or regime propaganda) and thanks to media control, authoritarian regimes can manipulate the economic perceptions of their

[20] Source: `https://www.tccb.gov.tr/en/news/542/147182/-turkiye-has-successfully-completed-yet-another-festival-of-democracy-with-may-14-elections-` (accessed: Feb 13, 2024).

citizens (Öztürk 2023), contemporary autocracies can enjoy genuine support for their societal model.

Our findings therefore help to understand the gradual democratic erosion that we witnessed in the past decade. Elected by popular support, leaders such as Orban in Hungary, Modi in India, and Erdogan in Turkey, gradually restricted core elements of democracy. This subtle backsliding includes tactics such as "censoring and harassing the media, restricting civil society and political parties, and undermining the autonomy of election management bodies" (Lührmann and Lindberg 2019*b*: 1098). Many of the steps taken to take control relate to the checks and balances of the political institutions. As our results show, governmental oversight is the least important element of democracy to people and might explain why they are willing to accept these violations as long as the elections (at least seem) to be free and fair.

Based on our estimation, only Australians are below 50% in their willingness to trade off checks and balances for prosperity, while a majority of citizens in all other 31 countries would be willing to do so. Across our sample, a staggering 39% of respondents are willing to trade off all three measured aspects of democracy – elections, civil rights, and executive constraints – for better economic prosperity. This ranges from 23% in Australia to 48% in Guatemala. In our view, these are concerning findings for the future and health of democracy. Significant proportions of citizens across the world appear to be willing to give up core democratic institutions.

The set of revealed preferences for different aspects of democracy identified in our study may shed light on why contemporary democratic erosion has been accompanied by citizens' consent in many countries. Citizens are not only willing to tolerate concrete instances of violation of democratic principles by politicians, as demonstrated in previous research, but many also seem to be quite favorable to the political system that autocratizing countries are moving toward. Finally, the finding that willingness to give up executive constraints in exchange for economic prosperity is quite widespread also in seemingly established democracies speaks to the universal appeal of electoral autocracy.

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Supplementary Material

The appeal of electoral autocracy: Assessing citizens' revealed societal preferences

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A. Appendix: Ethical consideration of research

This research relies on the contribution of human participants and adheres to the APSA Principles and Guidance for Human Subjects Research. The study was peer-reviewed and received ethical approval (number: XXX) from the University's Ethics Board before any data collection commenced. Here we briefly address some key ethical concerns arising from this study.

Participant recruitment and questionnaire: Research participants were recruited via Facebook/Instagram advertisements. Social media users saw our ads and by clicking on the ad were directed to a Qualtrics landing page, where they were first shown the Participant Information Sheet (PIS). The PIS included details about the research, the intended purpose (two research papers), the duration of the survey (10-15min), funding details of the project, and contact details for the research team and ethics board. We also provided participants with information on how their data will be stored and that participation is voluntary and can be ended at any time. They also received details about the prize draw used for compensation (see more details below). Only after people read these details and consented to their participation, were they taken to the survey.

We do not see any significant ethical risks for the participants of this study. The questionnaire included questions on political attitudes, which might be considered sensitive. However, all questions included have been verified by existing, peer-reviewed research and are commonly used in political science. We, therefore, do not believe that these questions led to any undue psychological harm.

Participant compensation: To recruit participants, we offered participants to enter a prize draw to win a voucher in the value of $500. In countries, where Amazon operates, we offered an Amazon voucher. If that was not the case, we offered a voucher to a comparable online retailer, which is available in the country. Participants were only eligible to enter the prize draws if they completed the survey and provided contact details, as otherwise, we would not have been able to contact them in case they won the lottery. Vouchers can easily be sent via text message or email in electronic form.

Data protection: There are no risks of identifying individuals in our data. Participants were in full control of whether and how much they wished to participate in the study. The only personal information collected from participants was their mobile numbers and/or email addresses to re-contact respondents after the initial data collection. However, this data was encrypted and saved separately from the survey responses. All data is stored on password-protected computers.

B. Appendix: Survey information

Figure A.1: Screenshot of country comparison in survey

Please carefully compare the countries and answer the questions below.

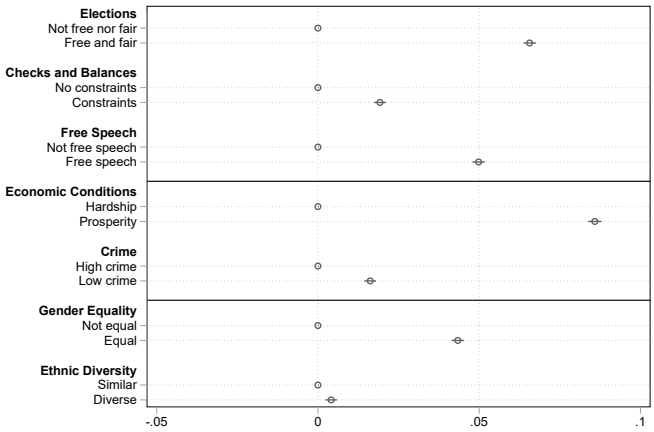
	Country A	Country B
Elections	Citizens go to the polls, but elections are neither free nor fair	Citizens elect their leaders in free and fair elections
Separation of power	Political leaders can rule without constraints from parliament or courts	Political leaders are constrained by parliament and courts
Free speech	People could get prosecuted by authorities when criticising the government in public	People can criticise the government in public without getting prosecuted by authorities
Equal pay	Men have higher wages than women	Men have higher wages than women
Diversity	People living in this country are ethnically and culturally very diverse	People living in this country are ethnically and culturally very similar
Economy	People generally live comfortably on their income and can afford most things that they need	Many people struggle to live on their income and must make decisions about what they can afford
Crime	Crime rates in the country are low and stable	Crime rates in the country are low and stable

Table A.1: Number of respondents and country profile observations for each country.

Country Name	Respondents	Observations
Argentina	2381	17314
Australia	408	3446
Bangladesh	1476	11450
Bolivia	859	6270
Chile	663	5256
Colombia	1539	11842
Dominican Republic	760	6044
Ecuador	735	5698
El Salvador	889	6550
Ghana	1240	10340
Guatemala	804	6252
Honduras	916	7052
Hong Kong	561	4656
India	1553	12756
Kenya	1813	15244
Malaysia	648	5382
Mexico	684	5554
Nicaragua	909	6526
Nigeria	2238	19072
Pakistan	1300	10072
Paraguay	797	5762
Peru	841	6466
Philippines	586	5388
Singapore	483	4068
South Africa	1220	9742
Tanzania	903	7304
Turkey	3149	27790
Uganda	1178	9366
United Kingdom	810	6494
United States of America	659	5372
Venezuela	809	6346
Zambia	1470	11686
Total	35281	282560

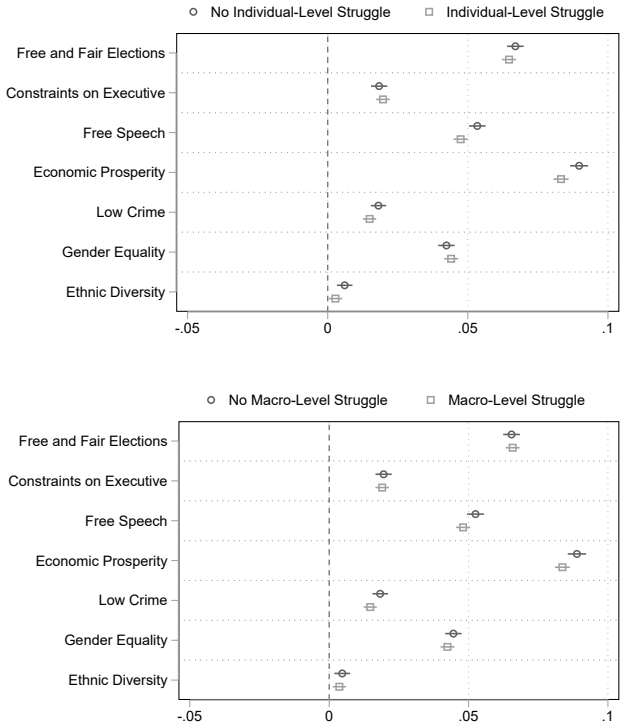
C. Appendix: Results using quality of life as outcome variable

Figure A.2: AMCEs of all attributes on quality of life outcome across the entire sample



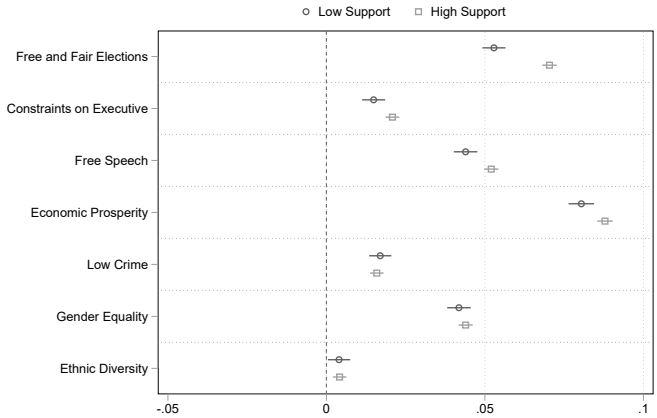
Note: 281,492 observations. Linear regression with country characteristics as independent variables and quality of life as the dependent variable. Standard errors are clustered on the respondent level.

Figure A.3: AMCEs of all attributes on quality of life outcome by individual- and macro-level economic conditions.



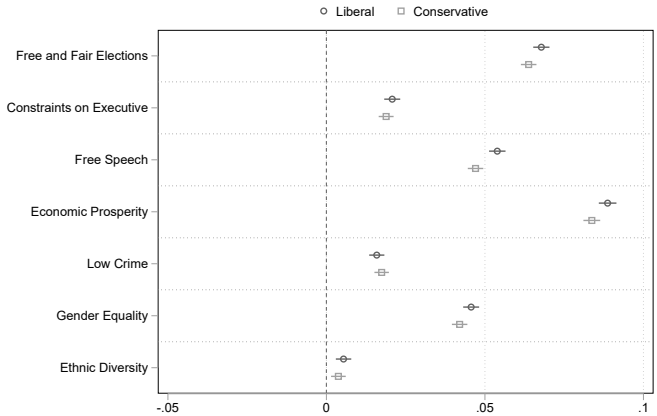
Note: 111,842-169,650 observations depending on size of economic conditions categories. Linear regression with country characteristics as independent variables and quality of life as dependent variable, conditioning on our measures of individual- and macro-level economic conditions. Standard errors are clustered on the respondent level.

Figure A.5: AMCEs of all attributes quality of life outcome by individuals' pre-existing democracy support.



Note: 75,635-205,857 observations depending on size of democracy support categories. Linear regression with country characteristics as independent variables and quality of life as dependent variable, conditioning on our measures of support for democracy. Standard errors are clustered on the respondent level.

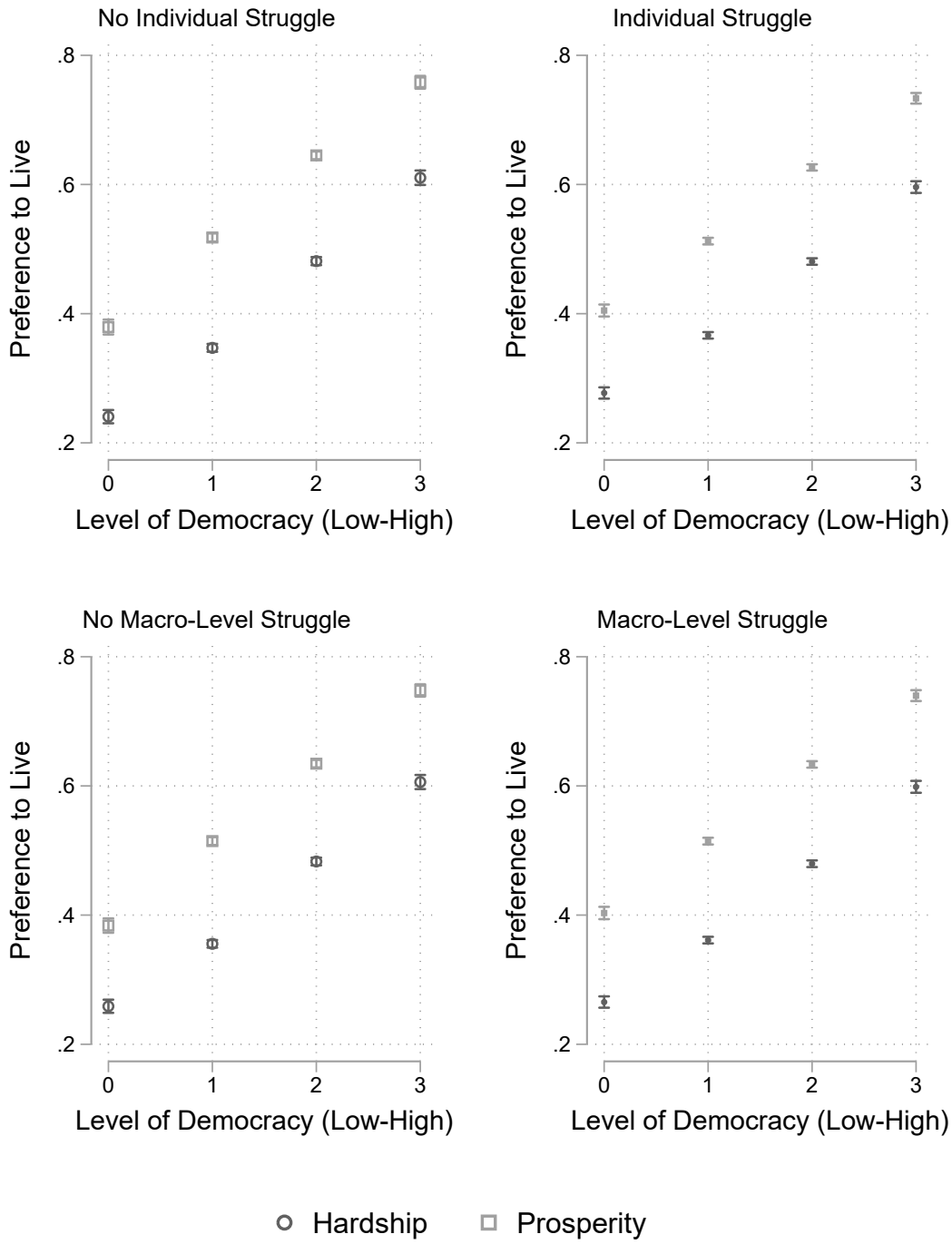
Figure A.6: AMCEs of all attributes on quality of life outcome by individuals' pre-existing social attitudes



Note: 156,345-173,372 observations depending on size of social attitude categories. Linear regression with country characteristics as independent variables and living preferences as dependent variable, conditioning on our measures of social attitudes. Standard errors are clustered on the respondent level.

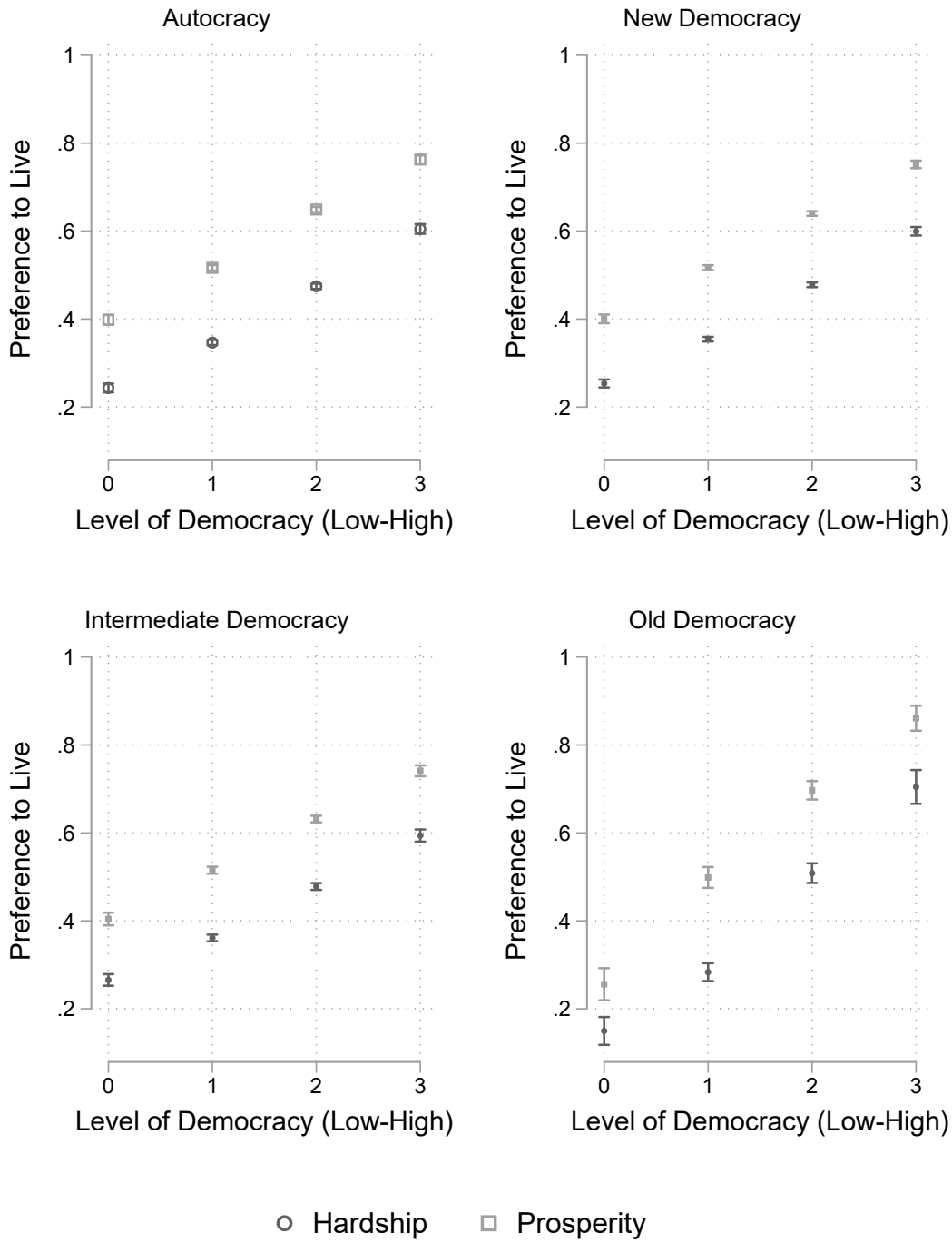
D. Appendix: Results of attribute bundles - Predicted values

Figure A.7: Living preferences for high (low) democracy and low (high) security country bundles by individual- and macro-level economic conditions.



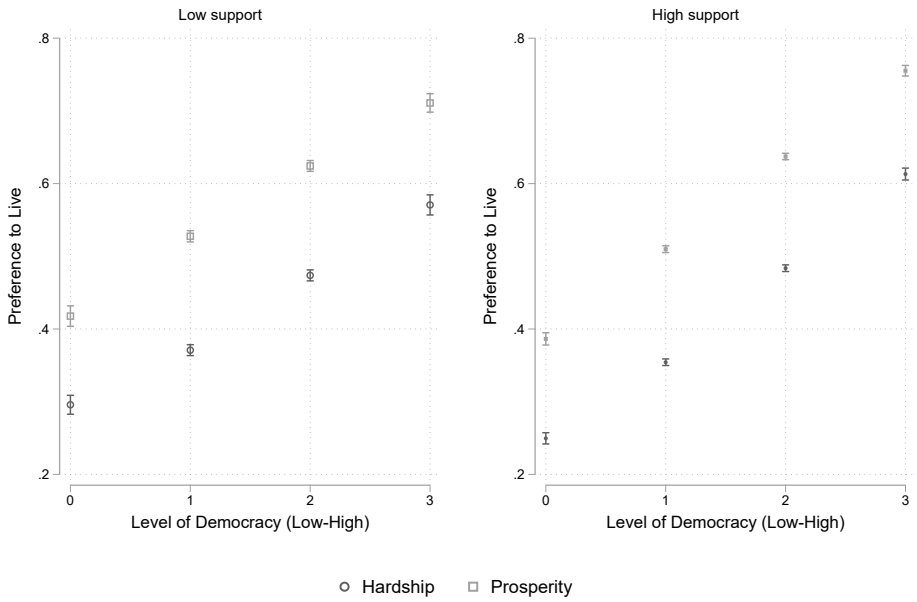
Note: 111,608-170,952 observations depending on size of economic conditions categories. Linear regression with our democracy scale and economic prosperity as independent variables, including an interaction term between the two, and living preferences as dependent variable – all conditioned by individual- and macro-level economic conditions. Standard errors are clustered on the respondent level.

Figure A.8: Living preferences for high (low) democracy and low (high) security country bundles by regime type.



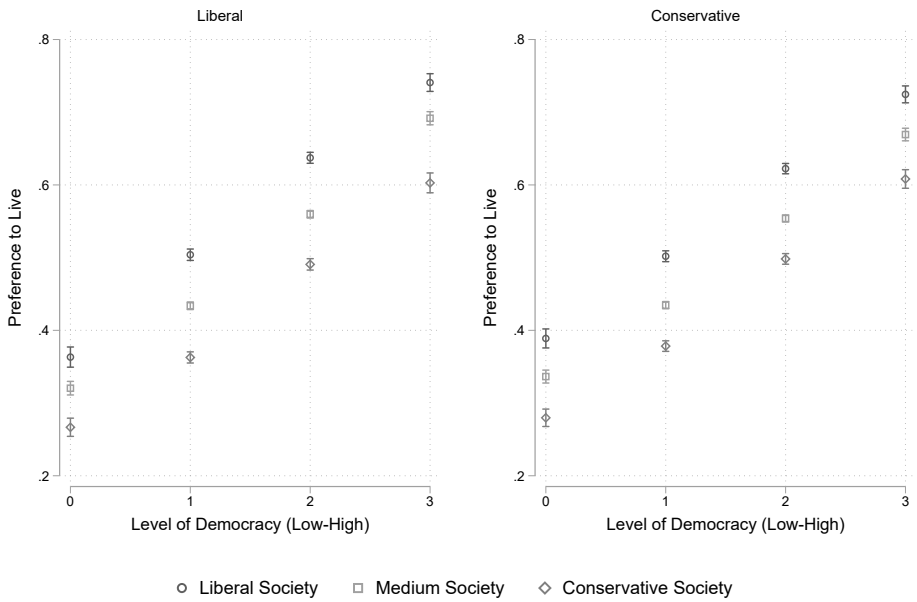
Note: 8,818-150,242 observations depending on size of economic conditions categories. Linear regression with our democracy scale and economic prosperity as independent variables, including an interaction term between the two, and living preferences as dependent variable – all conditioned by regime type. Standard errors are clustered on the respondent level.

Figure A.9: Living preferences for high (low) democracy and low (high) security country bundles by individuals' pre-existing democracy support.



Note: 76,248-206,312 observations depending on size of economic conditions categories. Linear regression with our democracy scale and economic prosperity as independent variables, including an interaction term between the two, and living preferences as dependent variable – all conditioned by support for democracy. Standard errors are clustered on the respondent level.

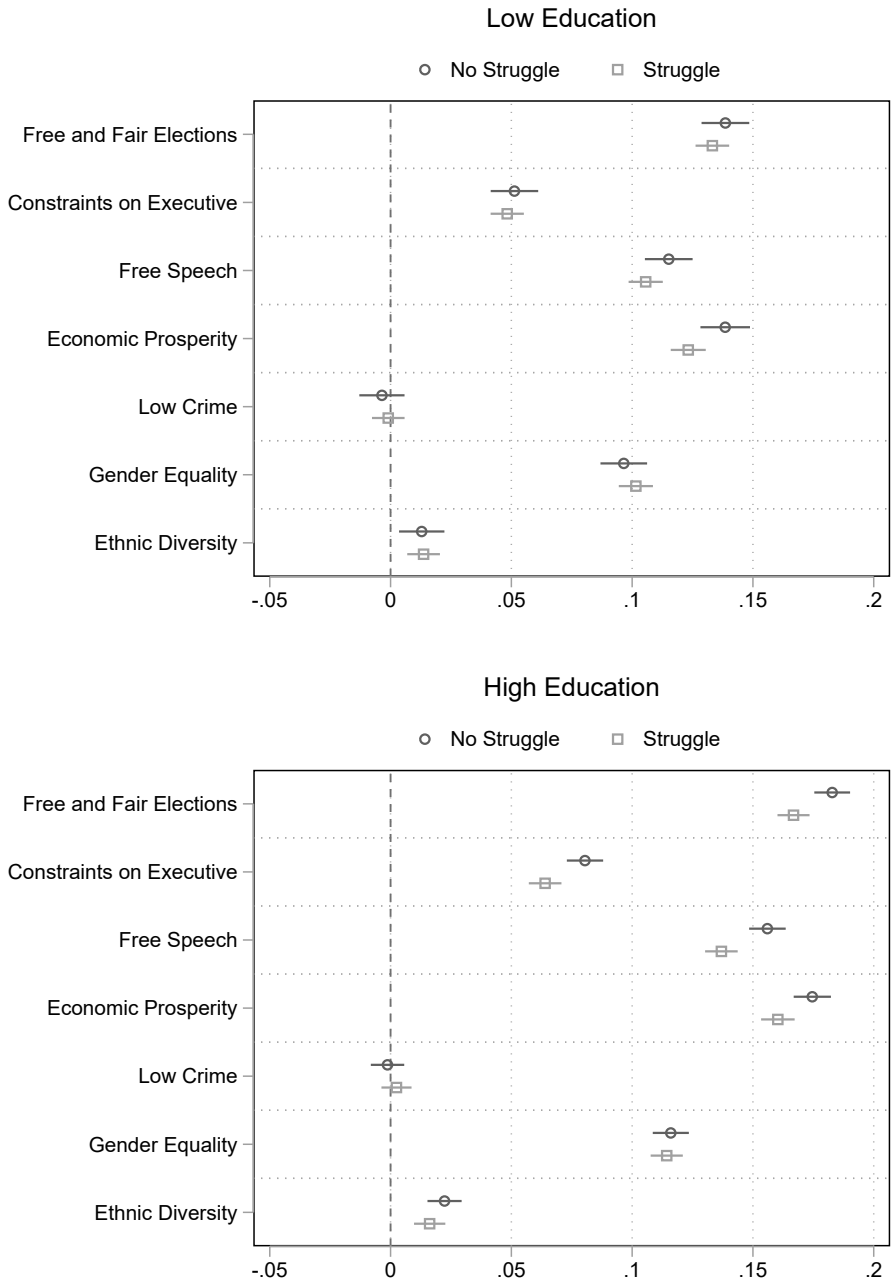
Figure A.10: Living preferences for high (low) democracy and low (high) security country bundles by individuals' pre-existing social attitudes.



Note: 154,960-175,074 observations depending on size of economic conditions categories. Linear regression with our democracy scale and economic prosperity as independent variables, including an interaction term between the two, and living preferences as dependent variable – all conditioned by individuals' pre-existing social attitudes. Standard errors are clustered on the respondent level.

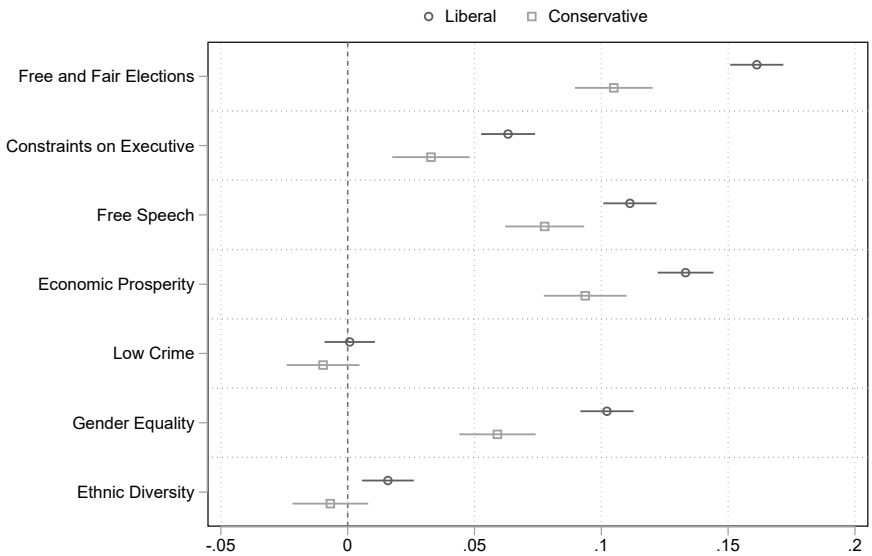
E. Appendix: Remaining Robustness Checks

Figure A.11: AMCEs of all attributes on living preferences by individuals' economic well-being split in respondents with low (below college) and high (college or higher) education



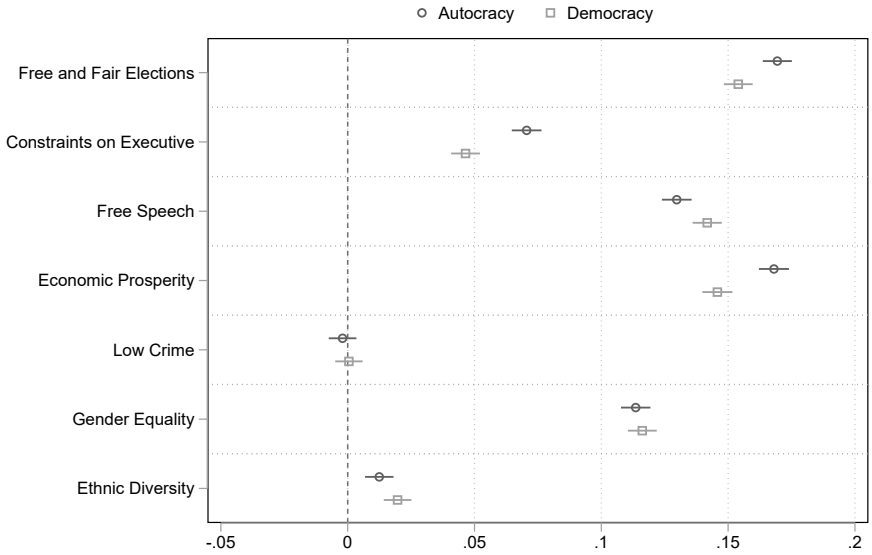
Note: 69,864-88,078 observations depending on size of economic conditions and education categories. Linear regression with country characteristics as independent variables and living preferences as dependent variable, conditioning on our measures of education and individual economic conditions. Standard errors are clustered on the respondent level.

Figure A.12: AMCEs of all attributes on living preferences by individuals' pre-existing social attitudes when splitting the sample in the 10% most liberal and conservative respondents.



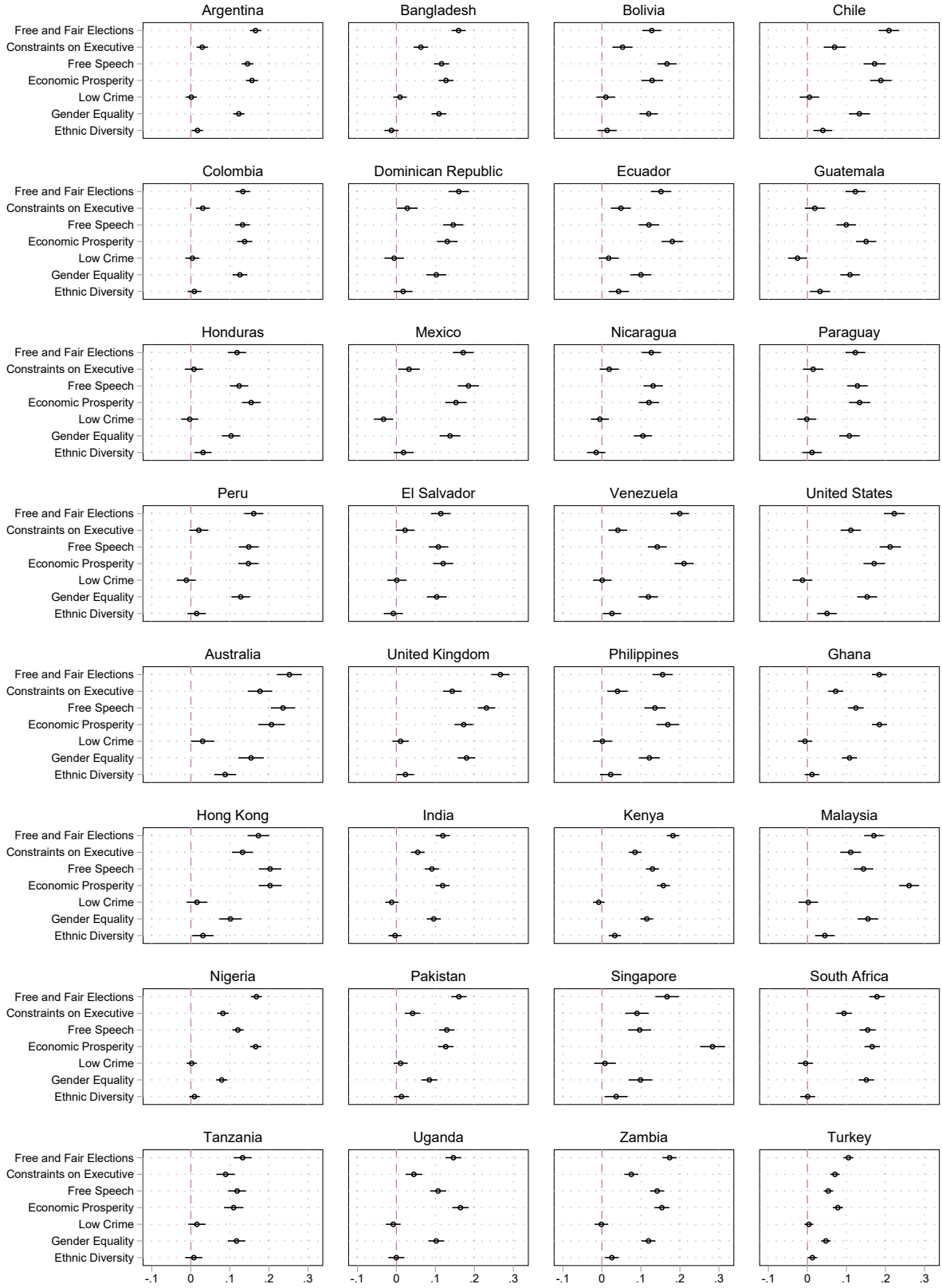
Note: 17,114-35,284 observations depending on size of social attitude categories. Linear regression with country characteristics as independent variables and living preferences as dependent variable, conditioning on our measures of social attitudes. Standard errors are clustered on the respondent level.

Figure A.13: AMCEs of all attributes on living preferences by regime, collapsing democracies and autocracies to a binary measure.



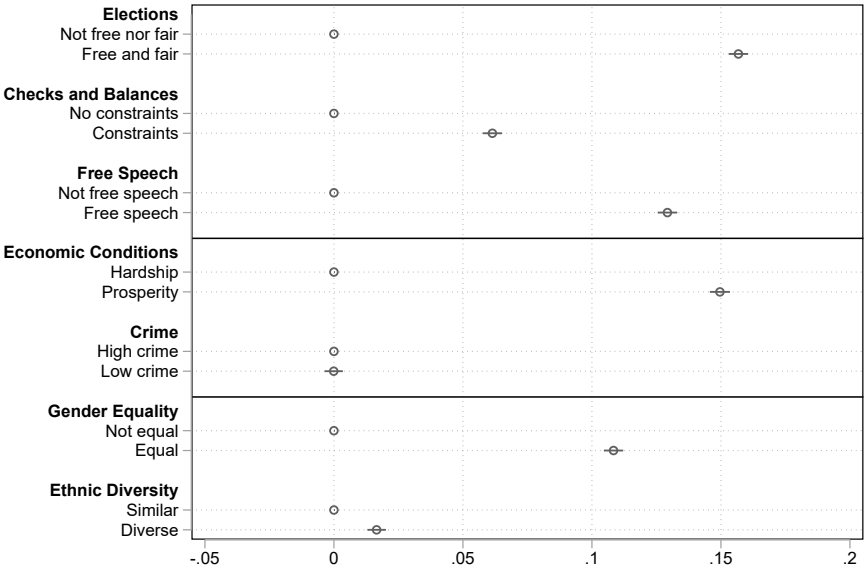
Note: 116,860-121,574 observations depending on size of regime categories. Linear regression with country characteristics as independent variables and living preferences as dependent variable, conditioning on a binary regime measure. Standard errors are clustered on the respondent level.

Figure A.14: AMCEs of all attributes on living preferences by country.



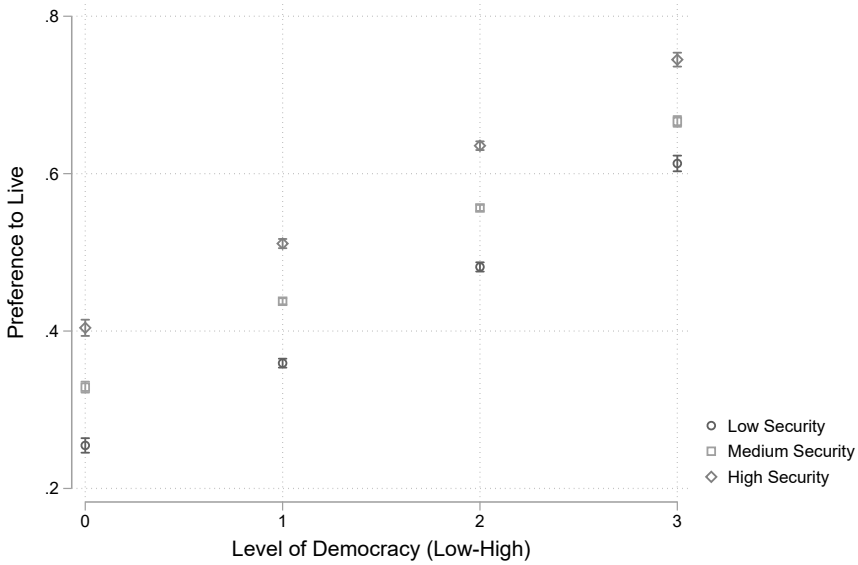
Note: 282,560 observations. Linear regression with country characteristics as independent variables and living preferences as the dependent variable by country. Standard errors are clustered on the respondent level.

Figure A.15: AMCEs of all attributes on living preferences across the entire sample when including country fixed effects.



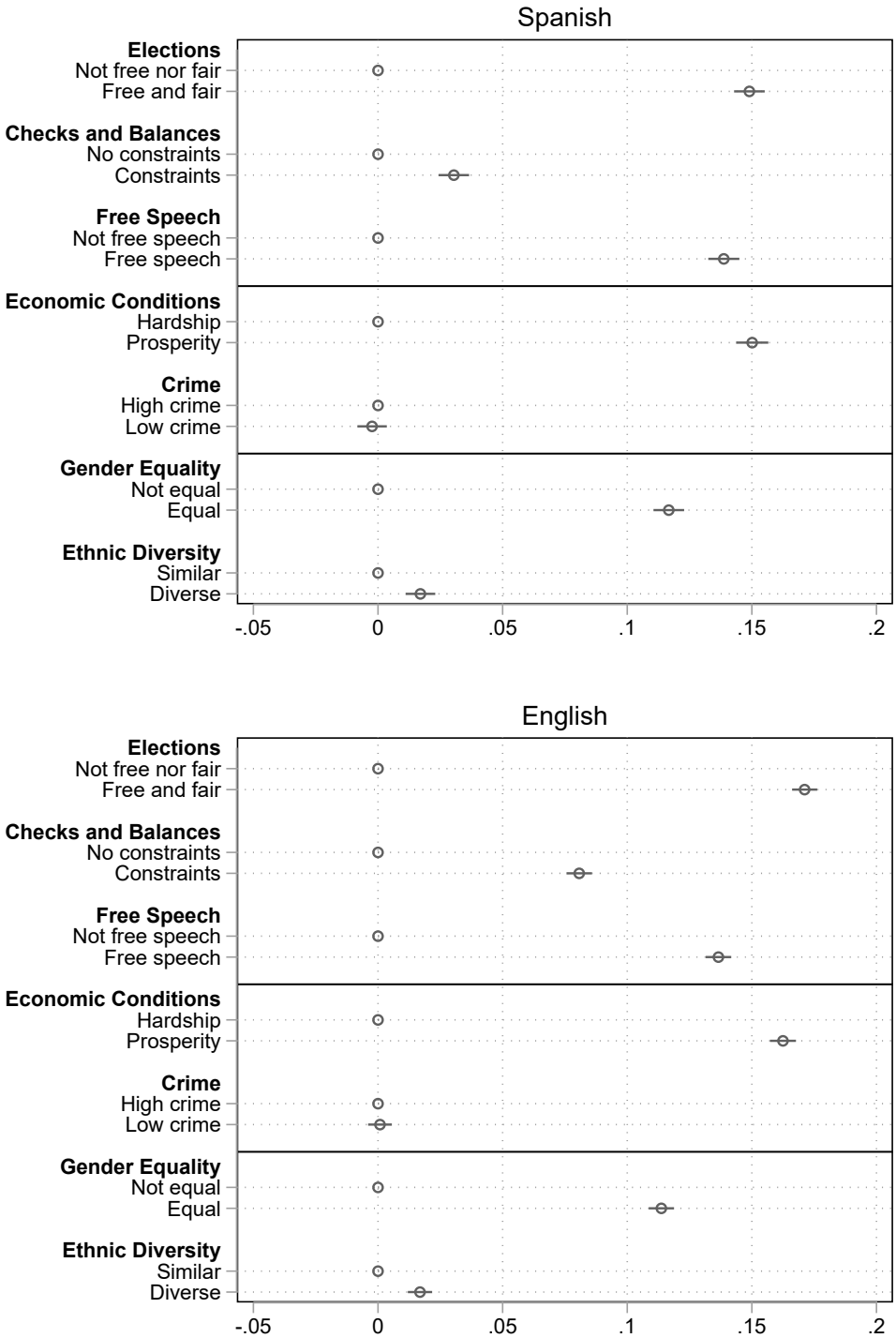
Note: 282,560 observations. Linear regression with country characteristics as independent variables and living preferences as the dependent variable. Country fixed effects included. Standard errors are clustered on the respondent level.

Figure A.16: Living preferences for high (low) democracy and low (high) security country bundles when bundling economy and crime



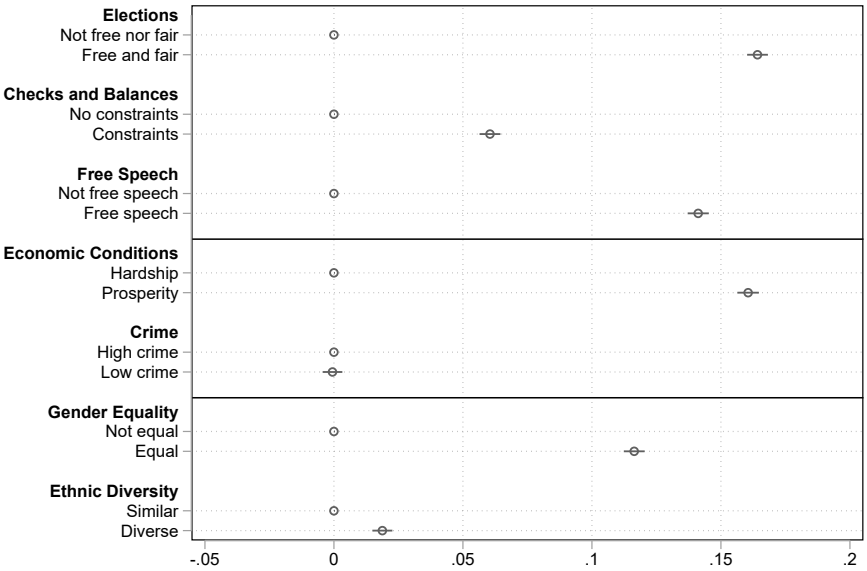
Note: 282,560 observations. Linear regression with our democracy and (bundled) security scales as independent variables, including an interaction term between the two, and living preferences as dependent variable. Standard errors are clustered on the respondent level.

Figure A.17: AMCEs of all attributes on living preferences by Spanish and English-speaking countries



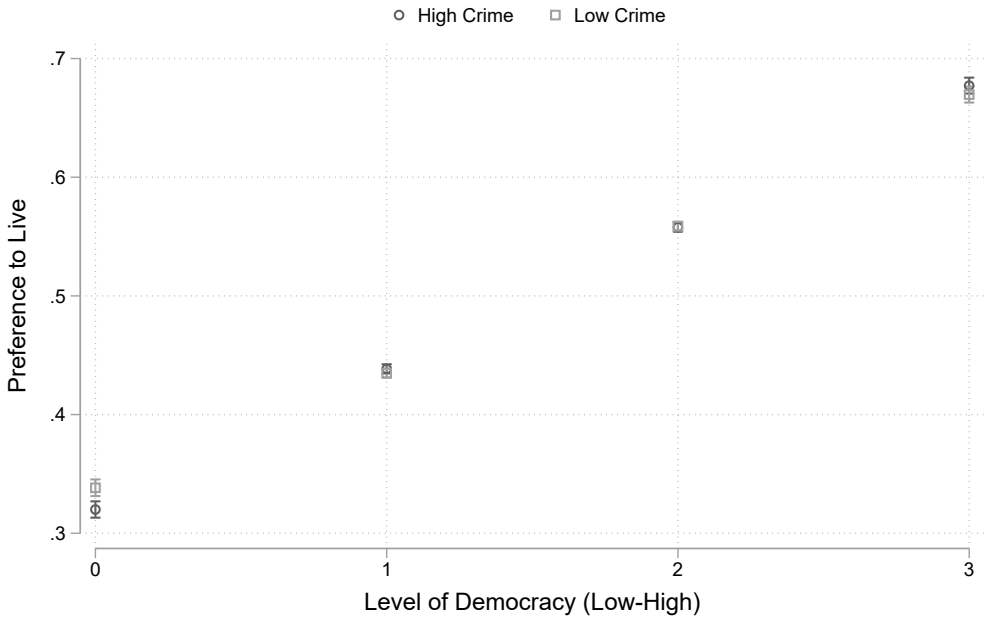
Note: 282,560 observations depending on language category. Linear regression with country characteristics as independent variables and living preferences as the dependent variable by language. Standard errors are clustered on the respondent level.

Figure A.18: AMCEs of all attributes on living preferences when only including language proficient respondents.



Note: 240,406 observations. Linear regression with country characteristics as independent variables and living preferences as the dependent variable. Only language proficient respondents included. Standard errors are clustered on the respondent level.

Figure A.19: Living preferences for high (low) democracy and low (high) security country bundles focusing on security as crime only.



Note: 282,562 observations. Linear regression with our democracy scale and physical security (crime) as independent variables, including an interaction term between the two, and living preferences as dependent variable. Standard errors are clustered on the respondent level.

F. Appendix: Tables with Additional Results

Table A.2: Percentages of citizens willing to trade elections, free speech, and checks on executive for absence of crime by country.

	Elections	**Free speech**	**Checks**	**All aspects**
Argentina	41%	43%	49%	35%
Australia	39%	39%	42%	18%
Bangladesh	42%	45%	48%	36%
Bolivia	44%	43%	48%	34%
Chile	39%	40%	46%	26%
Colombia	44%	43%	49%	36%
Dominican Republic	41%	42%	48%	31%
Ecuador	44%	44%	49%	37%
Ghana	40%	44%	46%	32%
Guatemala	44%	44%	47%	41%
Honduras	44%	43%	50%	36%
Hong Kong	42%	41%	45%	32%
India	44%	45%	46%	37%
Kenya	41%	43%	46%	32%
Malaysia	40%	43%	45%	28%
Mexico	40%	40%	47%	30%
Nicaragua	43%	43%	50%	37%
Nigeria	41%	45%	47%	34%
Pakistan	43%	45%	49%	35%
Paraguay	45%	41%	49%	37%
Peru	41%	41%	48%	32%
Philippines	43%	43%	49%	33%
El Salvador	45%	44%	49%	39%
Singapore	42%	47%	46%	35%
South Africa	40%	41%	45%	30%
Tanzania	45%	45%	47%	36%
Turkey	45%	47%	47%	39%
Uganda	43%	45%	47%	38%
Venezuela	39%	43%	48%	32%
United Kingdom	37%	38%	43%	19%
United States	37%	40%	44%	23%
Zambia	41%	42%	46%	32%
Observations	141,114	140,943	140,846	35,385

Table A.3: Percentages of citizens willing to trade elections, free speech, and checks on the executive for economic prosperity *and* absence of crime by country.

	Elections	**Free speech**	**Checks**	**All aspects**
Argentina	49%	51%	56%	40%
Australia	49%	50%	51%	24%
Bangladesh	49%	52%	55%	41%
Bolivia	51%	51%	55%	43%
Chile	45%	49%	55%	34%
Colombia	52%	51%	56%	44%
Dominican Republic	47%	49%	54%	37%
Ecuador	53%	54%	57%	43%
Ghana	51%	54%	56%	41%
Guatemala	51%	50%	55%	47%
Honduras	53%	53%	59%	45%
Hong Kong	49%	50%	54%	38%
India	51%	52%	53%	44%
Kenya	49%	51%	53%	42%
Malaysia	53%	57%	56%	40%
Mexico	47%	47%	54%	38%
Nicaragua	47%	48%	54%	39%
Nigeria	49%	52%	54%	43%
Pakistan	48%	51%	54%	39%
Paraguay	52%	47%	57%	48%
Peru	49%	47%	54%	37%
Philippines	51%	51%	57%	40%
El Salvador	53%	50%	55%	46%
Singapore	57%	61%	60%	48%
South Africa	48%	50%	53%	37%
Tanzania	50%	52%	53%	41%
Turkey	49%	51%	50%	42%
Uganda	51%	52%	55%	43%
Venezuela	51%	53%	58%	40%
United Kingdom	43%	47%	51%	23%
United States	48%	49%	53%	27%
Zambia	48%	51%	53%	38%
Observations	70,535	70,289	70,629	17,832

G. Appendix: Sample comparison to representative, weighted data

We compare the characteristics of our sample to reference data, which provides (weighted) representative data from each country included in our study. We calculated, for example, the percentage of women in our sample and the (weighted) reference data. On average we have 1% fewer women than what we would expect based on the reference data. Table A.4 summarizes the differences in several sample characteristics:

- Female respondents
- Those who respond 'very interested' or 'somewhat interested' in politics.
- People aged 34 and under (young).
- People aged 55 or older (old).
- People who do not have any qualifications or education higher than primary level.
- People who have an undergraduate degree or a higher degree.

Table A.4: Differences between study sample and representative data

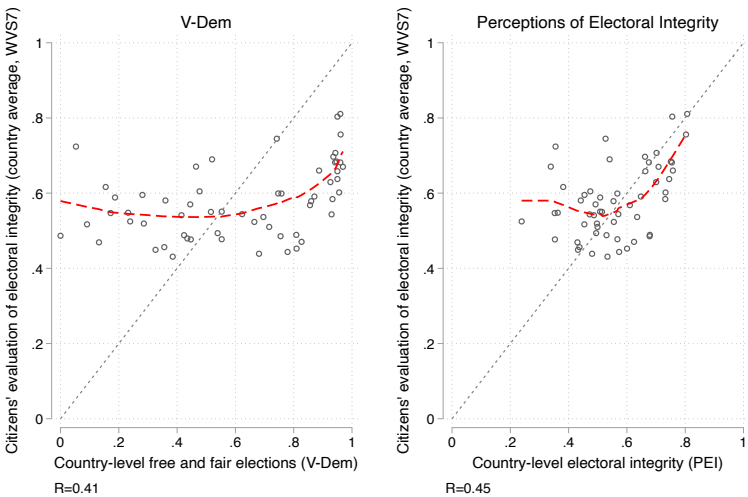
Country	Reference Data	Year	Weight variable	% Female	Pol. interested	Young	Old	No/prim ed	Uni ed
Argentina	WVS-7	2017	W_WEIGHT	3%	30%	-5%	3%	-21%	30%
Argentina	LAPOP21	2021	wt	4%	NA	-10%	10%	-12%	1%
Australia	WVS-7	2018	W_WEIGHT	-1%	24%	14%	-5%	0%	44%
Bangladesh	WVS-7	2018	NA - No weighting	-7%	13%	7%	2%	-44%	62%
Bolivia	WVS-7	2017	NA - No weighting	-4%	29%	-15%	11%	-18%	36%
Bolivia	LAPOP21	2021	wt	-4%	NA	-11%	14%	-13%	29%
Chile	WVS-7	2018	W_WEIGHT	0%	43%	12%	1%	-1%	41%
Chile	LAPOP21	2021	wt	0%	NA	5%	7%	-4%	22%
Colombia	WVS-7	2018	NA - No weighting	-3%	37%	-13%	12%	-17%	25%
Colombia	LAPOP21	2021	wt	-3%	NA	-7%	14%	-17%	16%
Dominican Republic	LAPOP21	2021	wt	0%	NA	25%	-10%	-34%	42%
Ecuador	WVS-7	2018	NA - No weighting	3%	25%	1%	6%	-15%	27%
Ecuador	LAPOP21	2021	wt	5%	NA	-3%	13%	-16%	23%
El Salvador	LAPOP21	2021	wt	1%	NA	1%	6%	-12%	9%
Ghana	AfroB2022	2019	Combinwt_new_hh	-6%	NA	19%	-12%	-38%	71%
Guatemala	WVS-7	2019	NA - No weighting	-6%	6%	-12%	9%	-3%	-26%
Guatemala	LAPOP21	2021	wt	-4%	NA	-1%	3%	-26%	-3%
Honduras	LAPOP21	2021	wt	-2%	NA	-1%	4%	-38%	27%
Hong Kong	WVS-7	2018	W_WEIGHT	-7%	46%	32%	-29%	-14%	48%
India	WVS-6	2012	NA - No weighting	-2%	29%	15%	-1%	-42%	64%
Kenya	WVS-7	2021	NA - No weighting	6%	20%	-37%	-1%	-12%	47%
Kenya	AfroB2022	2019	Combinwt_new_hh	6%	NA	-20%	-11%	-35%	53%
Malaysia	WVS-7	2018	NA - No weighting	2%	29%	6%	5%	-3%	54%
Mexico	WVS-7	2018	W_WEIGHT	1%	43%	-8%	7%	-23%	28%
Mexico	LAPOP21	2021	wt	2%	NA	-8%	7%	-23%	21%
Nicaragua	WVS-7	2020	NA - No weighting	-7%	11%	-18%	8%	-22%	26%
Nicaragua	LAPOP21	2021	wt	-6%	NA	-22%	13%	-23%	27%
Nigeria	WVS-7	2018	W_WEIGHT	-10%	20%	-4%	0%	-26%	67%
Nigeria	AfroB2022	2021	Combinwt_new_hh	-9%	NA	9%	-5%	-33%	70%
Pakistan	WVS-7	2018	NA - No weighting	0%	18%	-3%	14%	-41%	68%
Paraguay	LAPOP21	2021	wt	-4%	NA	4%	0%	-24%	18%
Peru	WVS-7	2018	W_WEIGHT	2%	43%	0%	6%	-13%	35%
Peru	LAPOP21	2021	wt	3%	NA	-5%	12%	-9%	7%
Philippines (Spanish)	WVS-7	2019	W_WEIGHT	0%	-24%	18%	22%	14%	-9%
Philippines (English)	WVS-7	2019	W_WEIGHT	6%	-7%	8%	-3%	-31%	34%
Singapore	WVS-7	2020	W_WEIGHT	-5%	33%	33%	-21%	-10%	26%
South Africa	AfroB2022	2022	Combinwt_new_hh	-3%	NA	-39%	27%	-10%	31%
Tanzania	AfroB2022	2022	Combinwt_new_hh	-5%	NA	13%	-8%	-72%	67%
Uganda	AfroB2022	2019	Combinwt_new_hh	-3%	NA	-16%	-7%	-52%	60%
United Kingdom	WVS-7	2022	W_WEIGHT	6%	20%	-3%	8%	1%	23%
United States	WVS-7	2017	W_WEIGHT	1%	16%	12%	-7%	3%	24%
Venezuela	WVS-7	2021	NA - No weighting	-6%	26%	-20%	21%	-14%	41%
Zambia	AfroB2022	2022	Combinwt_new_hh	0%	NA	-6%	-4%	-37%	66%
AVERAGES				-1%	23%	-1%	3%	-20%	34%

H. Appendix: Citizens' perceptions of free and fair elections

To assess whether citizens understand such complex concepts as "free and fair elections", we explore survey data from the 7th wave of the World Value Survey (WVS) in more detail. The data includes 63 countries, which include 22 of our cases. Data was collected between 2017 and 2022. We generate an index measuring different, concrete aspects of electoral integrity and how respondents evaluate these in their home country. More specifically, respondents were asked "how often in [their] country´s elections..." (responses: 1. not at all often to 4. very often): [1] 1) Votes are counted fairly; 2) Opposition candidates are prevented from running; 3) TV news favors the governing party; 4) Voters are bribed; 5) Journalists provide fair coverage of elections; 6) Election officials are fair; 7) Rich people buy elections; 8) Voters are threatened with violence at the polls; 9) Voters are offered a genuine choice in the elections; 10) Women have equal opportunities to run the office.

All ten items were recoded from the least to the most integer election evaluation. The items were combined into one index, calculating the average response to all items (row mean). Figure A.20 plots the average country-level value of this index by the country-specific electoral context. To measure the latter, we rely on two measures. The left panel uses V-Dem's free and fair elections index (year=2019), while the right panel uses the Perception of Electoral Integrity index (year=2018). The indicators used to generate these indices map well onto the items asked to the WVS survey respondents.

Figure A.20: Average citizens' perceived and country-level electoral integrity



Notes: The figures include the lowess estimators as well as the 45-degree reference lines.

References

Mauk, Marlene and Max Grömping. 2023. "Online Disinformation Predicts Inaccurate Beliefs About Election Fairness Among Both Winners and Losers." *Comparative Political Studies* p. 00104140231193008.

[1] Unlike the study by Mauk and Grömping (2023) we include all available items in the index, while they only select five.